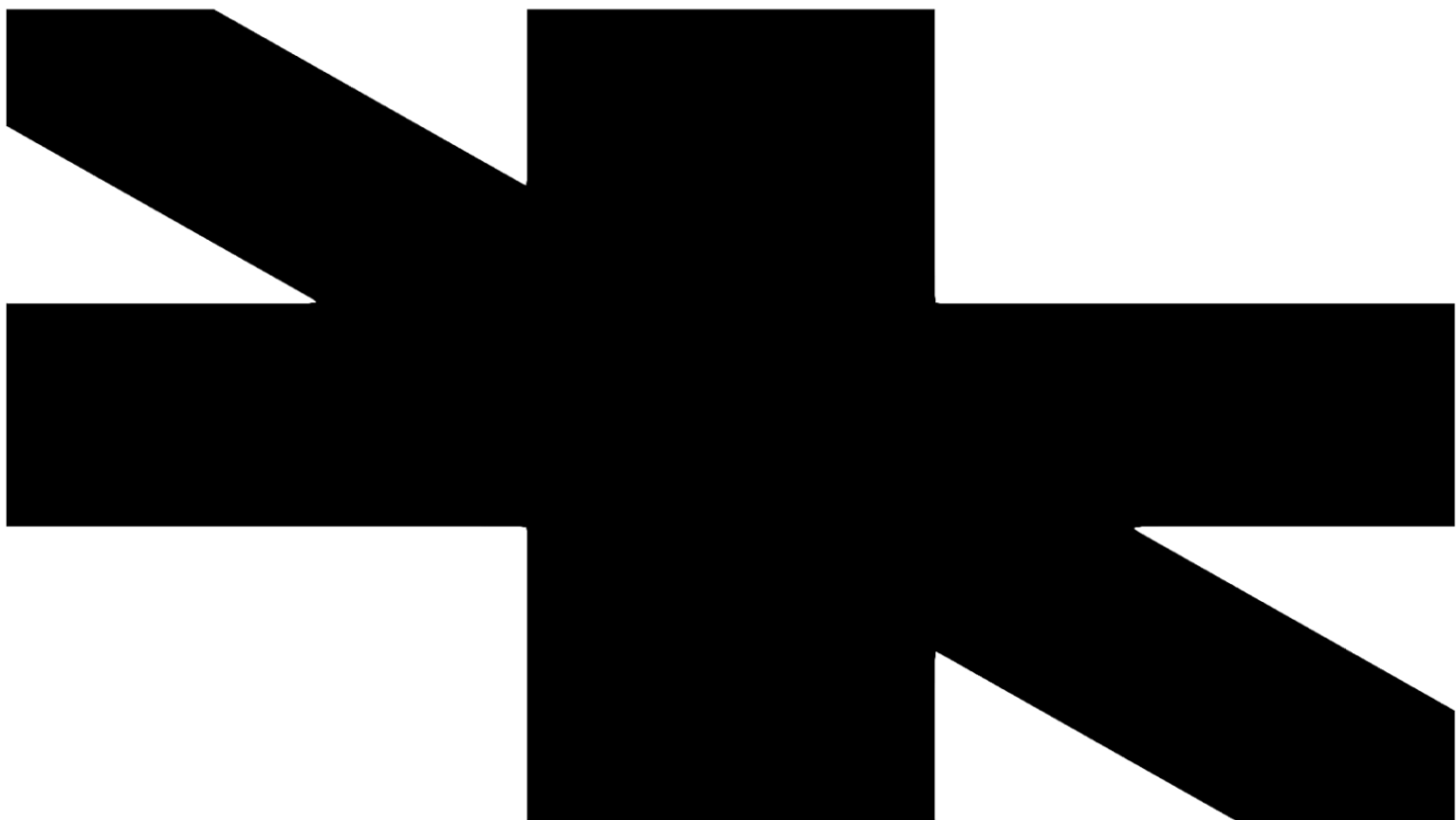




TRANSFORMISM

Piotr Wyrzykowski

Academy of Fine Arts in Gdańsk



AKADEMIA
SZTUK
PIĘKNYCH
W GDAŃSKU



ZBROJOWNIA
SZTUKI

TRANSFORMISM

POTENTIAL POWER OF ART

Piotr Wyrzykowski

Supervisor: **Prof. Robert Florczak**

Academic Advisor: **Prof. ASP Dr. hab. Małgorzata Jankowska**

Field of art, discipline of art and conservation of artworks

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INTRODUCTION

Art as a tool for consciousness transformation has been the foundation of my thirty-year artistic practice. From this perspective, my thesis is: art transcends merely aesthetic roles, prompting potential social and political changes. I firmly advocate that an artist's influence should not be confined to galleries. For this reason, from the beginning of my career, I have undertaken interdisciplinary projects in diverse spaces, intending to evoke significant changes and create provocative artistic works. I debuted as a performance artist (Ziemia Mindel-Wurm, Galeria Wyspa, 1990), creating video works, computer works, websites, installations, actions, and projections in public spaces, as well as mobile applications. I merge these mentioned genres into new, cross-genre forms, performing fusions and connections, which generate new meanings and perspectives. The decision to address the topic of transformation arises from observing that if there's something constant in my life and career, it is change itself. Allow me a brief personal digression, which will explain the origin of my interest in the subject of changes and their impact on reality. For unknown reasons, I had the fortune (though this is relative—could it be misfortune? However, friends joke that wherever I go, a protest erupts) to personally experience three revolutions and understand their consequences. In Poland, in Gdańsk, during the 1980s, I hid in gates and churches from ZOMO, escaping from the shipyard gate. Living in Ukraine, in Kyiv, in 2004, when the city was pulsating with optimism, and the streets were filled with music played from cars—this was the Orange Revolution, which reminded me more of the early 1990s Love Parade in Berlin (where I lived in squats in the eastern part of the city) than a social protest. Finally, in 2013, the Dignity Revolution on the Maidan in Kyiv—bloody, brutal, and dangerous. I will never forget how my Ukrainian friends gifted me a crowbar for protection against the so-called titushky. With that piece of metal hidden under my jacket, I stood on the Maidan at night, surrounded by hundreds of thousands of people holding up glowing phones (instead of candles) during the funeral of activists. These experiences reinforced my belief that nothing is permanent, that society has the potential to influence its future and choose better paths, but unfortunately, it can also squander its opportunities.

Considering the above reflections for research purposes, I will employ the concept of "transformism." It's a concept that refers to the potential power of art and its ability to transform the consciousness of individual viewers and society as a whole. My research will be based on the fundamental theory of **affirmative nomadic ethics** of Rosi Braidotti¹ and the resulting theory of **affirmative humanities** by Ewa Domańska², as well as the ideas and conclusions presented by Łucja Iwanczewska³. In exploring the potential power of art and its ability to provoke change, I will rely on examples from my own works, categorized according to the strategies of establishing relationships.

CHANGE

Transformism is a concept that pertains to change and provoking change through art. It would be appropriate, then, to start by defining the concept of change. And try to clarify, what is change?

Change, in an academic context, is typically defined as: *"a process in which someone or something becomes someone or something with different properties."*⁴

To invoke change in the classical sense requires establishing contact between the object and the author of transformation by applying a specific "force vector", leading to a modification of the object's state, e.g., setting it in motion. In the world of classical physics, this phenomenon is defined in Newton's second law of motion: *"If an unbalanced constant force acts on a body, the body moves with acceleration. The acceleration is directly proportional to the acting force and inversely proportional to the body's mass."*⁵ Mathematically, this is expressed as:

$$F=ma$$

Where: **F** is force, **m** is mass, and **a** is acceleration.

¹ Rosi Braidotti, "Ethics of Becoming Undetectable," Translated by Joanna Bednarek. In "Subversive Theories: Anthology of Translations," edited by Agnieszka Gajewska. Poznań: Poznań Publishing House, 2012.

² Ewa Domańska, "Affirmative Humanities — Gender and Power after Butler and Foucault", In Contemporary Culture. Theory, Interpretation, Practice. Warsaw: NCK, 2014. e-book

³ Łucja Iwanczewska, "Potentiality of Transformation. Short Duration of Cultural Performances in Poland in the 90s". Warsaw: IBL. 2022. e-book

⁴ Zmiana <https://wsjp.pl/haslo/podglad/7699/zmiana/5106027/proces-przejscowy> 1.10.23

⁵ Il Netwon <https://eszkola.pl/fizyka/ii-zasada-dynamiki-3658.html>, 31.10.23

In this context, the change of interest to us is the result of the application of specific forces on an object by the author of transformation. In quantum physics, reality is more complex. Here, the traditional concept of an object and its interactions is challenged. In the world of subatomic particles, an object can exist in many states simultaneously, and its exact state is determined only upon its observation, as described by Stephen Hawking: *"In quantum physics, particles do not have well-defined states until they are measured. All possibilities exist simultaneously..."*.⁶ In the context of transformism, the concept of information becomes pivotal. In the quantum world, a particle's state can change without direct contact, through the exchange of virtual particles like photons, which can be interpreted as quanta of information. In the "network society", much like in quantum physics, information is the key unit of interaction. *"In quantum theory, information about the state of a particle, such as an electron, can be transferred to another particle through a photon, which acts as a quantum of information."*⁷ Transposing Zeilinger's information theory to the socio-political sphere and Castells' concept of the "network society", I would venture to claim that they both exhibit similar phenomena of communication and information exchange. In the network society, individuals and groups are connected by informational networks that allow real-time exchange, processing, and dissemination of information. Much like in the quantum realm, where information about the state of a particle is transferred to another particle without physical contact, in the network society, information flows between individuals and groups in intricate networks, irrespective of physical space. This means that in the network society, much like in the quantum world, relations and interactions are defined by informational networks, rather than by physical proximity or direct contact. Thus, Castells' notion of networked communication and information exchange in the network society is, in a way, analogous to the quantum phenomena described by Zeilinger. In the context of art and transformism, this means that artistic works can provoke change not necessarily through direct experience but also through networked informational resonance. Transformism, in this context, can be understood as a "quantum of information". Just as in quantum physics, where

⁶ Stephen Hawking, "A Brief History of Time", Warsaw, Alfa Publishing, 1990.

⁷ Anton Zeilinger, "Dance of the Photons: From Einstein to Quantum Teleportation". New York, Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2010. e-book

observation affects the observed phenomenon, interactions in the network society are multifaceted. Artworks in transformism are not merely passive objects for observation but active participants in dialogue with the viewer. The analogy to the network society emphasizes that, in transformism, artistic interventions do not impact in isolation but create resonant waves in the social network, leading to more extensive changes. Change can be both positive and negative, with its evaluation often depending on context and viewpoint. This entire process influences behaviors, relationships, and the functioning of individuals and specific social groups, e.g., students, by introducing or removing subjects like religion or arts from the curriculum. It's also worth noting that change can be short-lived or enduring and can either be gradual or radical. Observing the ensuing change might require the use of specialized tools and methods, and the fact of its observation impacts the state of change.

In the context of art, the change introduced through a work pertains to the potential of utilizing artistic creativity as a tool for establishing a dialogue with society (without dialogue, change cannot be evoked) and influencing social and political realities. Based on the experiences acquired during the projects of the C.U.K.T. group (to which I will refer as a co-founder and artistic director of the office, particularly the project titled: "Presidential Campaign of Victoria Cukt", 1999-2000), an artist can (or at least try to) reshape reality by designing and envisioning a better world. By actively involving recipients (co-creators) in the project, they can present reality as a more understandable and visible stage on which we conduct our experiments, provoking change. Artists, taking on this challenge, abandon traditional forms of artistic expression and advocate for direct contact with society in favor of participatory, interdisciplinary, performance, interactive art located in public spaces. They reduce the work to a package of information and experiences intended to provoke resonance in the form of a transformational information sphere.

The concept of information as the primary layer of an artwork is pivotal in the context of implementing change. The democratization of access to information and technological advancements transform art into a tool for opposing cultural, political, and social injustice. As previously mentioned Manuel Castells pointed out: *"A more significant and more stable source of power, however, is constructing meanings in human minds. The way people think determines the fate of the institutions, norms,*

and values around which societies are organized."⁸ From this perspective, art as information can influence the perception and understanding of the world, e.g., by giving a voice to the marginalized and creating a space where their voice becomes dominant, even if only during a performance.

The transformation of reality perception, induced by participation in an artistic project, is a form of revising our perceptions and interpretations of the surrounding world. It is experiencing new issues and perspectives that challenge our previous beliefs. For an individual, such a change can signify new forms of understanding and interpreting the environment, leading to a change in attitudes, beliefs, and even behaviors. On a societal level, it can lead to the evolution of norms, values, and expectations.

Change in the perception of reality is a continuous process, shaped by various factors. As Castells emphasized: *"In the network society, power is multidimensional and organized around networks, programmed in every area of human life in a way that corresponds to the interests and values of actors with a strong position. Communication networks are therefore the basic sources of power in society."*⁹ In this context, transformism in art, as a tool for provoking a change in perspective and introducing transformations, is related to the idea of networks and the impact of mass communication on human minds.

In the context of society, the transformation of reality perception can lead to significant changes in social, cultural, or institutional structures, since the perception of reality plays a key role in shaping norms, values, and social expectations. For instance, a change in the perception of gender or race can contribute to promoting equality and the principle of non-discrimination in society.

The connection between life and art is crucial in my understanding of the concept of transformism. As I mentioned before, I have experienced life during a period of transformation and had the chance to influence changes and the emergence of new phenomena in Poland. Engaging in art and being an artist has always been, and remains for me, a kind of political act associated with a sense of co-responsibility for the surrounding social reality. This attitude leads to the need to attempt to change the environment. It is worth noting that in Gdańsk at the end of the 90s, there were no suitable spaces for presenting modern art, and the PWSSP was an institution with

⁸ Manuel Castells, "Networks of Outrage and Hope: Social Movements in the Age of the Internet", Warsaw, PWN, 2013. p. 17

⁹ *ibid*

a traditional approach, which made it difficult to find the right place for oneself. Especially for someone who came to classes with a pink-painted bass guitar with torn-out frets.

In the early 90s, I was engaged in cultural processes, initiating the formation of artistic groups and informal communities, and actively participating in numerous non-governmental organizations that led to the creation of new institutions and art venues. I co-created, among others, the Wyspa Progress Foundation, where I served as the vice-president, which led to the establishment of the Open Atelier, later transformed into the Łaźnia Contemporary Art Center. Moreover, I was involved in the activities of a group of students from PWSSP in Gdańsk (establishing the Independent Student Union), which led to the establishment of the "Pi" Intermedia Workshop (led by Witosław Czerwonka) at the Painting Department, which after our graduation was transformed into an independent department.

For me, art is not just an aesthetic composition whose message is based on its beauty - the perfection of form. The potential for change it can bring is crucial, starting from the artist himself, his life, the audience, the immediate environment, and more broadly - the reality in which it operates and the language of art. The conceptual potential inscribed in the artistic project has a revolutionary character - the artist tries to record a given system of transformation forces in the synthetic form of the work. To visualize what is often hidden for others and to initiate a transformation process.

Concluding this chapter, I will once again refer to Manuel Castells' theory and his concept of the "network society", where the basic social structures and actions, the exercise of power, are organized around electronic information networks. In this perspective, change is not simply evolution or adaptation to new circumstances, but rather a dynamic negotiation process. Power, identity, and social functions are inextricably linked and redefined (negotiated) through an ongoing dialogue in the flow of information. An artist can strive to bring his unique voice into the vast field of information, although his impact is niche and often unnoticed in a broader social context. Therefore, the artistic strategies

(discussed below) constructed by artists with the idea of reaching society with their information and transcending a niche role seem so important.

DEFINITION OF TRANSFORMISM

Transformism = Art + Revolution + Education + Liberation.



Illustration 1: P. Wyrzykowski, "Graffiti Transformism", 2023, private collection.

Art serves as the foundation and base for transformism, as it is through artistic actions and projects that reality is provoked, various concepts are explored, and current issues are addressed.

Revolution here represents the change that is indispensable for the process of transformism.

Education plays a pivotal role in the process of transformism, signifying that art should shape societal awareness and contribute to increasing knowledge about social issues as well as facilitate access to and conscious utilization of information.

Liberation pertains to the goal of transformism, which aims to free people from constraints, inequalities, and injustices that hinder them from fully realizing their potential.



Illustration 2: P. Wyrzykowski, "How Many Cuts Are Needed to Find Yourself Outside? Axe I", Tallinn Art Hall, Tallinn, 1993, private collection.

In 1993, at the renovated Tallinn Art Hall in Tallinn, which was established in 1934, I performed the first act of deliberate destruction of a pristine white exhibition wall, initiating a series of three performances titled "How many cuts are needed to find yourself outside?". The horrified reaction and scream of the

gallery director, who was unaware of my actions, may serve as evidence in defense of the thesis I posit in my work: art has the potential to transform the world.

An act of intentional destruction, such as the one I carried out during my performance at the Tallinn Art Hall, can elicit strong emotional responses and challenge established conventions and norms. By tearing into the immaculate white wall, I aimed to convey the message that art, like the body, is not confined to the boundaries of the gallery space or our muscular form but has the power to break free and transcend traditional limitations far beyond our perceived boundaries.

By brutally hacking a hole into the wall in Tallinn, I was destructively creating, laying the foundation for the concept that art is more than just an object confined in the white cell of a gallery, isolated from the world and society, displayed for admiration like a savage in a cage during a carnival freak show. Both in Tallinn and in Gdansk, 30 years later, while carving out "Transformism" for the subject of my doctoral work, I was unaware of the 19th-century French scientist Jean-Baptiste Pierre Antoine de Monet, Chevalier de Lamarck, who in 1809 proclaimed a pre-Darwinian theory of evolution called "Transformism" or Lamarckism. Lamarck posited that organisms did not arise through a divine act of creation but evolved from one another, undergoing gradual changes and transformations influenced by constant environmental conditions, leading to the emergence of new species. Lamarckism is a theory he introduced in the early 19th century, persuasive due to its simplicity. He argued that *"life took its present form through natural processes, not miraculous interventions"*¹⁰ and that these processes drive animals to develop traits to fulfill specific needs. Jean Baptiste de Lamarck illustrated his theory vividly using the famous example of giraffes.

¹⁰ "Early Concepts of Evolution: Jean Baptiste Lamarck", evolution.berkeley.edu, (29.10. 2023).



Illustration 3: P. Wyrzykowski, visualization of the idea of transformism, stretching a giraffe's neck, private collection.

According to him, giraffes stretched their necks to reach the highest tree leaves because lower food sources were exhausted. As a result, their necks gradually extended to their current length. Although Lamarck's theory was later overshadowed by Darwin's theory of evolution, one might wonder if in art there is also a process of "stretching one's neck" by exploring new techniques, technologies, and artistic communication methods. In art, much like Lamarck's theory on the development of giraffes, we can observe that artists are continually searching for new expressive forms and communication methods with the viewer.

Transformism in art primarily signifies the belief that change, in accordance with the definition of the word "trans" – reaching "beyond", positioning "on the other side," is the foundational function of artistic expression. It's not its aesthetic aspect, the "beauty," but the potential of provoking the trembling of "form" – meaning the "inner structure of things" – that is paramount. It's about provoking a tremble, which means a change of state or position, and simultaneously a change of meaning. It's widely accepted that art that moves us, touches us. This experience evokes physical sensations, reactions in our

body, and is typically accompanied by emotions — affects. Eliciting reflexes in the viewer and provoking reactions is one of the primary transformative components of experiences constructed by artists. Returning to the director from Tallinn, her scream during my performance sounded as if I wasn't striking the wall of her gallery, but striking her personally. My hand with the axe extended significantly, trying to transcend the boundaries of form and the gallery confined by its walls. Going beyond oneself and beyond the gallery became a long-term ideological premise of my artistic activity.

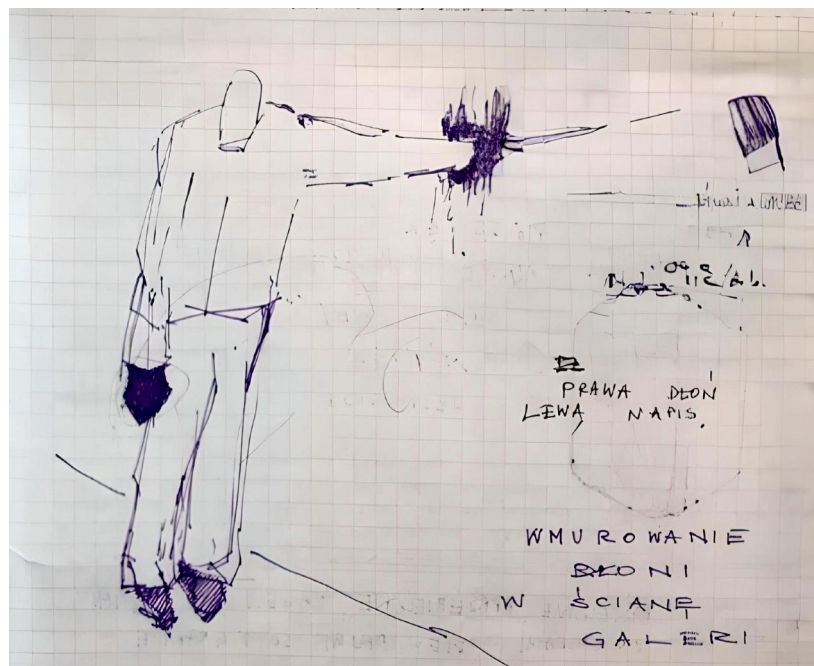


Illustration 4: P. Wyrzykowski, project of an unrealized performance: embedding hands in the wall of a gallery, 1993, private collection.

In transformism, it is precisely the artist's consciousness that must undergo transformation first. The individual understanding of the meaning of existence, the motivation to act, and the way of perceiving the world and relationships formulate the final effect and concepts of the work. The artist must have the desire, and they must find the means and form for their expression; they cannot be afraid to experiment and take risks.

Another aspect is experimenting with the language of art and the form of communication with the viewer, drawing attention to selected aspects of reality and changing their perspective. The artist often provokes and asks questions, allowing for eliciting reactions and drawing attention to a particular issue.

As I mentioned above, transformism is a concept that refers to change and provoking change through art. Its aim is to inspire the transformation of individuals, who, in the case of my doctoral project, undergo a metamorphosis from refugees to superheroines. However, in the broader context of artistic activities, transformism refers to the change in consciousness or the state of the viewer caused by the impact of a work of art. Łucja Iwanczewska perfectly explains the understanding of art in transformism, describing artistic projects: *"[...] as archives of modernizing, libertarian, egalitarian, and affirmative potentiality, which contained a scenario of potential changes taking place in contemporary social life. Writing about potentiality, I think primarily of power, strength, possibilities, i.e., something that can be realized, towards which specific actions can be taken."*¹¹

It is precisely the potential for change contained in the ideological layer of the artwork that interests me the most. This is not about an activist approach to art, which focuses solely on achieving a specific goal and directly working on selected social or political problems. It's mainly about potential, provocation, and openness, which the artwork establishes as a portal for future actions in various forms, aiming to implement the declared ideas. I would like to emphasize that these actions can be taken, but they do not have to be, and their form can take various shapes. The ambiguity and openness in the realization of provocation contained in a work of art are as important as achieving the intended goal.

¹¹ Łucja Iwanczewska, "Potentiality of Transformation. Short Duration of Cultural Performances in Poland in the 90s". Warsaw: IBL. 2022. e-book

AFFIRMATIVE NOMADIC ETHICS

My interest in transformation in the realm of art stems from a deep conviction that change is possible, generated by forces arising as a result of actions taken in artistic projects.

The obvious change is the metaphorical neck of the giraffe, signifying the development of artistic methods and changes in the language of art, resulting from the development of concepts of successive works. The use of new forms of expression and media, especially related to digital generation of audiovisual content. In my dissertation, I try to trace attempts to initiate the direct influence of art on the world, emphasizing: movement, affectivity, and change are key concepts in affirmative nomadic ethics. A philosophy that, according to Rosi Braidotti, is *"...focused on becoming as a pragmatic philosophy, emphasizing the need for action, experimenting with various ways of constituting subjectivity and various ways of inhabiting our corporeality."*¹²

Transformism fits into the perspective outlined by the researcher. Its central figure is the so-called *"nomadic subject,"*¹³ which is a *"being-in-the-making"*¹⁴ in constant motion, undergoing changes, operating in a dynamic process of becoming and having a high potential to provoke changes in its environment. Such a state results from an affirmative approach to reality. According to Braidotti, *"These processes work, transforming negative passions into positives through the power of understanding that no longer fits within the phallogentric set of standards based on Law and Lack but is unhinged, and thus affective. The task of turning negativity into positivity is an ethical process of transformation. It aims at understanding, by becoming aware of our boundaries, our bondage."*¹⁵

¹² Rosi Braidotti, "Ethics of Becoming Undetectable", Trans. Joanna Bednarek. In *Subversive Theories: Anthology of Translations*, ed. Agnieszka Gajewska. Poznań: Wydawnictwo Poznańskie, 2012. e-book

¹³ *ibid*

¹⁴ *ibid*

¹⁵ *ibid*

In the philosophy of nomadic ethics, identity is viewed as something elastic and evolving, not as a constant. Human identity and the effects of its actions are constantly in the process of forming, changing in interactions with others and their surroundings. This concept is very close to projects in art, described as "work in progress" — a work that is never finished, always open to subsequent versions. The central figure of this philosophy remains the agency of the subject, which actively shapes reality and continually transcends the boundaries of its capabilities.

In this philosophy, a human is not considered a static entity but rather a dynamic being that constantly shapes and changes its world while being shaped by it. This approach encourages creativity and experimentation since every change is seen as natural and inevitable. The nomadic subject, the central figure of this philosophy, is an entity in constant motion, undergoing changes and functioning in a dynamic process of becoming. This being has a high charge of potential that can provoke changes in its surroundings.

That's why "work in progress" projects are so close to this philosophy. This approach allows for openness to subsequent versions of the work, which constantly evolves and changes with the creating subject. The subject's agency is central in this philosophy, as it is responsible for shaping reality. This philosophy emphasizes experimentation and creativity, allowing for the continuous discovery of new possibilities and the expansion of boundaries.

An affirmative approach to reality and oneself is a prerequisite for the activity and agency of an active subject. Such an approach involves a positive and accepting relationship to the reality in which the subject operates and to oneself as a person participating in it. This is the opposite of nihilism, which rejects all values and significance of reality, and of stagnation, which leads to inactivity and lack of progress.

An affirmative approach, seeing reality as something valuable and significant, allows the subject to take a creative and active approach to it, seeking new possibilities and ways of development, thus developing its potential and agency. A subject showing such an approach is open to experiencing new

things, takes on challenges, and moves towards the future, not losing hope for its positive aspects.

In this way, an affirmative approach to reality and oneself allows for the development of the subject's agency and activity, contributing to its positive impact on the surrounding world. As a result, the subject becomes more open to interactions with others and the environment, develops its abilities and skills, and contributes to positive changes in its surroundings.

The affirmative nomadic ethics sees the artist and man as an open process constantly changing and developing. The creative process itself is for him not only a way of expressing himself but also a chance to discover deeper areas of existence and conscious functioning in the world. A subject that professes an affirmative approach to reality and oneself becomes more aware of its potential and ability to act creatively. An affirmative approach is a prerequisite for creation.

Does art have a direct impact on reality? This topic sparks much debate. It depends primarily on the definitions of the words "impact" and "reality", as well as on the art itself. For me, however, it is clear that artistic creativity has a strong influence, which changes the way the world is perceived, affecting our awareness of its reception. As Władysław Strzemiński said, *"Only what a person has realized — he has actually seen. The rest remains outside his consciousness, unrecognized and therefore unseen."*¹⁶ Through works of art, we change the perspective of seeing the world, which allows us to read systems and the balance of forces dictating our existence differently. Art helps us become aware of existing interdependencies affecting our current state. This concerns not only political and social ties but also biological ones, as well as connections between the individual and society, man and nature, other species, and virtual entities. Such an understanding of art's influence is based on the primary importance we attribute to language and the power of the word. Through them, we construct our theoretical hierarchies of meanings, trying to

¹⁶ Władysław Strzemiński, "Theory of Vision", Kraków: Wydawnictwo Literackie, 1958. p 15

clarify the reality surrounding us or our activity. Art is also a kind of specific language, often requiring us to use a translator for the proper reading of works and their interpretation. For me, the performative potential of the language of art is interesting. As Strzemiński said regarding unism, it has a certain "productive fiction", provocation, appearance of action, and is aggressively oriented towards reality with the motivation to change it. It is precisely the conceptual potential of art in creating reality that is the foundation of its agency and transformative strength — transformism.

In my interpretation, referring to language is related to the belief in the elementary component of all content and message — information. Unfortunately, we live in times when we have repeatedly experienced the destructive power of manipulating information and the dire consequences, changes in politics, and society. However, this is not the subject of my text, although I have addressed this extremely important contemporary topic in my works. (I will only mention the "Presidential Campaign of Victoria Cukt", C.U.K.T., 2000 and "The mobile phone is a surveillance device allowing its user to conduct a conversation. J. Assange", public space performance, 2013, Gdańsk).

In information as the supreme concept, I see the possibility of creating the world.

Combining information, dynamic identity, and an active subject in the form of an expanded body, which creates both itself and the surrounding world, refers to my hypertext from 1996 entitled "Expanded body of technical culture". In this text, I tried to understand and define theoretical and philosophical frameworks for artistic actions. I would now like to quote selected fragments because, surprisingly for me, they relate to the philosophy of affirmative nomadic ethics:

"Expanded Body of Technical Culture"

0.0.0 Language is the body.

0.0.0.0 Does creation require a body?

0.0.0.1 What isn't a body?

0.0.0.2 The process of creation is a process of organizing the body.

0.0.0.3 Changes in art concern methods of organizing the body and maximizing its openness.

0.0.0.4 What would the complete dissolution of the body entail?

1.0.0.3 When I say "I," I don't just mean myself within the boundaries of my physical form but also my room, apartment, profession, car, surname, first name, family, homeland, etc.

1.1 My body is the information I identify with.

1.1.0 Information is not just a message but the avant-garde of duration.
W. Sedlak

1.1.0.1 I believe in information.

1.1.0.2 Information as a transformative factor.

1.1.0.3 Information as a binder of systems.

1.1.0.4 Information as a guarantor of activity.

1.1.1 Information not only sustains life but sets its new directions.

1.1.3 Identification transforms the body.

1.1.3.0 Identification is a gesture of consent, permission, acceptance.

1.1.3.1 The deeper my identification, the richer my body.

1.1.3.2 How deep can identification be?

1.1.4 Identification opens the body.

1.1.4.0 Identification is a gesture of absorbing information.

1.1.4.1 Identification unites us with the body of the world.

1.1.4.2 Identification - opening.

1.1.4.3 Openness is an agreement to the diversity of the world.

1.1.4.4 The egotism of an artist enclosed by the body of his work has nothing to do with openness.

1.1.5 Identification relates to the very essence of self-awareness, (mine).

1.2 The space of art is my body.

1.2.0 Changing the size of the art space is a function of the body.

1.2.0.1 The body needs physical and mental space.

1.2.0.2 Body development is essential.

1.2.0.3 All social phenomena - the state and art have their roots in our relationship to our own body.

The form of this text is not arbitrary and directly alludes to the work of L. Wittgenstein. Why? The following quote by Ray Kurzweil provides a fitting answer: *"Both the Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus and the logical positivist movement emphasize that physical reality exists irrespective of our perception of it. However, we can only know about it through what we perceive with our senses – which can be enhanced by tools – and based on logical conclusions drawn solely from sensory impressions. Essentially, Wittgenstein is trying to*

describe the methods and goals of science."¹⁷ This text draws upon Wittgenstein's philosophy, which underscores that our senses are pivotal in perceiving physical reality. Concurrently, both art and science have their distinct methods and objectives. Thus, this text pertains to the role of art in shaping and perceiving reality, which is inseparable from how we perceive the world through our senses.

In his philosophy, Wittgenstein posited that the meaning of words emerges more from the context and usage of language than from any inherent values ascribed to the words. This perspective acknowledges fluidity and ambiguity, akin to R. Braidotti's nomadic ethics.

Braidotti proposes an ethics centered on perpetual becoming, the abandonment of fixed identifications, and the acceptance of constant change and plurality. Much like Wittgenstein, there are no fixed definitions or identities here.

Some elements of Wittgenstein's philosophy may also echo Braidotti's idea of subjects as networks of relations. Wittgenstein argued that meaning and understanding arise from networks of associations and usage in specific contexts, similar to how Braidotti envisions subjects as networks of relations and connections. Connection and relation are paramount aspects of transformism. As I previously mentioned, without establishing a relation or contact, change cannot occur since the provocateur cannot influence the subject. The subject remains beyond their reach. Hence, in the next part of my dissertation, I will focus on the crucial aspect of artistic strategies of establishing relations.

Embracing the perspective of nomadic ethics, art isn't perceived as a fixed, immutable object but as a dynamic process of becoming, subject to continuous transformation and connections across various experiential levels. According to the affirmative nomadic ethics philosophy presented by Rosi Braidotti, the continuation of changes and the process of transformation are

¹⁷ Ray Kurzweil, "How to Create a Mind? The Secrets of Human Thought Revealed". Warsaw, Studio Astropsychologi, 2018.

fundamental elements of a subject's existence. This concept can be extended to understanding contemporary art as a process where creativity isn't merely a static artifact but embodies a continuous process of development, metamorphosis, and becoming. Contemporary art, as a dynamic expressive tool, serves as a medium facilitating dialogue between reality, the artist's vision, and the audience. These multifaceted interactions allow for experiencing diverse perspectives and reinterpretations of reality, thus stimulating the evolution of consciousness. Art can therefore prompt subjects to reconsider their premises, feelings, and perspectives, thereby inciting a change in their awareness.

By engaging with contemporary art, subjects can experience the process of becoming, which is fundamental to nomadic ethics, leading to a transformation of their own consciousness.

ARTISTIC STRATEGIES FOR ESTABLISHING CONNECTIONS

In this chapter of the dissertation, I will refer to my artistic achievements so far, comparing them with selected works from the history of art. I aim to highlight two key aspects. Firstly, my goal is to show that the topic undertaken in the doctoral thesis is a continuation of my many years of artistic work and research. It is an area that I continuously develop and modify, striving to discover new, more perfect forms of expression and building relationships with the audience. Secondly, as I mentioned earlier, one cannot overlook the issue of making contact if we want to understand the process of change and the strategies used by artists to interact with the system. This step is necessary and justified in my research.

Art, in my opinion, in its essence, is a source of provocation and change, operating on an emotional and intellectual level with the task of reaching society. Through his work, the artist becomes a guide to content aimed at prompting the viewer to reflect on their environment, social relations, and current issues, encouraging them to

actively engage in the process of changing the current reality or creating conditions for individuals to actively exist on the social dialogue scene.

Initiating changes in the established system is a complicated process that requires direct immersion in a given phenomenon. The artist, through his work, should penetrate reality, enabling the recipient and reality itself to evoke reactions that together contribute to evolution. This interaction is dynamic and mutual, meaning that the artist, on the one hand, is inspired by the changing world, rich in information and diversity of people, and on the other, influences reality through his works, causing changes.

In this context, reactions are mutual and provocative. To interact with the existing system and evoke reactions, the artist must construct various forms of information transmission that are both intriguing and sufficiently flexible to reach the recipient and encourage them to react, changing the state of affairs. The artist must not only be able to convey content but also adapt his work to the needs of the recipient and also speak their language to be understood and inspire them to reflect and act. He must be absolutely transparent in his actions and open to others. The artist, bravely naive and at the same time authentic, becomes a catalyst for change, creating a space where recipients can find their answers, break through limitations, and engage in transformations.

In the above context, I would like to discuss various artistic strategies that I used to shape my works and enable them to interact effectively with reality and establish relationships to provoke change.

SELECTED PROJECTS AND STRATEGIES

Below, I provide a description and analysis of selected projects in the context of the doctoral thesis topic. Projects have been compiled and classified according to the adopted artistic strategies.

Parallel to Reality

"We are at home, or we are not here."¹⁸

In this section, projects arising from deep identification with the immediate socio-political reality and a developed sense of the artist's co-responsibility for ensuing changes are presented, serving as a description and reaction to the ongoing transformation. These actions form an efficacious subject of an evolved body.

This strategy assumes that the artist engages in the socio-political reality and identifies with it so deeply that they feel co-responsible for the changes that are taking place. This allows the artist to create projects that not only describe but also respond to changes in the surrounding reality. As a result, projects are created that aim to influence social and political changes.

Forming an efficacious subject of an evolved body involves building awareness of one's physicality and its impact on reality. The artist then becomes an acting subject who fully utilizes their body to create projects that are both a description and a reaction to the surrounding reality. As a result, the created projects have a greater impact and influence on society. An example can be the performance titled "Thief" by Ewa Partum from 1970. Ewa Partum broke into the Contemporary Gallery in Warsaw and stole all the paintings that were on display. She entered the gallery in the evening when it was closed to the public. She had a crowbar with her, which she used to smash the glass in the cabinets with paintings. She then took all the paintings and ran out of the gallery. Partum hid in her friend's apartment and did not admit to the theft. Eventually, the paintings were recovered and returned to the gallery. Partum was arrested and fined. (from "Ewa Partum. Interviews").

In all three performances described below, the reason for their creation was my belief in the direct, physical connection of my person with socio-political events in Poland. Not the conviction about the importance of these events themselves, but the impossibility of separating them from my body. I was guided by faith in the power of individual gestures and events that seemingly affect each other independently. The statement "We are at home, or we are not here" became the motto of many of my actions. It speaks of the necessity to accept the place and oneself in this place and

¹⁸ Piotr Wyrzykowski, "On the Developed Body of Technical Culture", internet, 1996.

to overcome the nihilistic punk attitude of "No Future" in favor of the affirmative attitude of an efficacious subject. The radicalism of this confession is expressed in its opposition to the slogan often seen hastily painted on walls in the 1980s: "Shoot or emigrate!"



Illustration 5: Inscription on my primary school no. 25 in Gdańsk, 1981, photo by P. Wyrzykowski.

Existence that cannot live in the world comfortably, safely, in short — in its proper place, experiences and actualizes conflict within its body. It gives the conflict a physical nature (cutting oneself, burning oneself, etc.). It either tyrannizes or indulges its body, which becomes a theater where one experiences what cannot be experienced in the world.

"Copyright", exhibition "Antibodies", CSW Castle, Warsaw, 1993.

I attempted to address the aforementioned issue in the following manner: I had the copyright symbol tattooed on my right arm. My decision was a direct result of the introduction of a new copyright law in 1994. The magnified process of getting the tattoo was displayed on a monitor within the borders of Poland, cut out from a map of Europe. Throughout the tattoo artist's work on the circled "c", I read selected paragraphs from the law. On one hand, I recognized the global shift caused by the introduction of this law on the functioning of creators in Poland. On the other hand, by marking myself with the copyright symbol, I encompassed my entire being (all of

Poland) as "Myself." It's "I" who decides about the right, the form, and the work. The right to decide on any procedures on my body, its copying, or its destruction belongs to me. I am Poland, and I give a part of myself to myself. It's also essential to note that from that moment on, this symbol accompanies me for the duration of my life.



Illustration 6: P. Wyrzykowski, "Copyright", tattoo on the right arm, 1993, photo by T. Wyrzykowska.

„NATO Now. Safe Poland or No Poland at all”, 1993-95.

Due to a sense of danger and Russia's aggressive policy threatening the deployment of missiles in the Kaliningrad region, I personally became involved in promoting the necessity of Poland's accession to NATO. I wanted to be a NATO artist. To belong to the larger organism of united Europe. To go beyond the previously very strictly defined and closed borders of the Polish state. To feel equally safe and free in all directions of the space I "inhabit." By directly overlaying the map of Europe onto my body in subsequent performances, I pointed out the threats and conditions resulting from the geographical location of Poland.



Illustration 7: P. Wyrzykowski, "NATO Now! Safe Poland or no Poland at all.", Romania, 1994, private collection.

My chest became a representation of Europe, where I extinguished matches on the most volatile places of the time, such as Chechnya, Ireland, the Basque Country, and former Yugoslavia, burning spots onto my skin. I elucidated Poland's geopolitical position and the need to shift the border of a unified Europe eastwards, stretching the skin on my torso. A flaming map of Europe was projected onto me via a video

projector. With each subsequent performance, whether in Germany, Romania, Finland, or Canada, I emerged with new scars.

*"Performance NATO Now! Safe Poland or No Poland At All" was Wyrzykowski's response to the debate surrounding Poland's accession to the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. After the fall of communism, Poland regained its independence in foreign policy, but the West was skeptical about admitting it to NATO structures for fear of a negative reaction from Moscow. Former U.S. Secretary of State Henry Kissinger proposed that Poland and other countries of the former Eastern Bloc form a so-called "neutral belt." Wyrzykowski's performance was a gesture expressing the artist's concern about the stagnation of changes taking place in democratizing Poland - staying outside of NATO would subject the country to further belonging to the Russian sphere of influence. Treating his body as a map of Europe was a manifestation of the artist's "identification" with the social reality in which he lived. The emotional expression of this performance stemmed from recognizing Poland's fate as identical to his own."*¹⁹

I described this performance as a "poster performance" with a clear and unambiguous message, where subsequent actions aimed to convey information to the audience's consciousness and anchor it in their minds for longer. A performance often lives on after its completion by the artist in the form of stories about it, sharing impressions and questions with friends. The information becomes independent, operating outside the initiating event.

"Presidential Inauguration - December 23, 1995, 7:00 PM" Mózg Club, Bydgoszcz, 1995

For me, an equally significant moment in the recent history of Poland was the takeover of the presidency by Aleksander Kwaśniewski, who defeated the outgoing president, the legendary figure Lech Wałęsa, in democratic elections. Kwaśniewski's inauguration took place the day before Christmas Eve in 1995, a day that is special in itself. My entire performance was tailored to the schedule of the first Polish television channel. I began at the same time as the regular special children's

¹⁹ NATO Now! <https://artmuseum.pl/pl/filmoteka/praca/wyrzykowski-piotr-nato-now-safe-poland-or-no-poland-at-all> 01.11.23

program, "Dobranocka," and ended during the evening news. Initially, my face was hidden under a Santa Claus mask, then I sequentially adopted various masks: cut-outs from propagandistic posters of Lech Wałęsa and Aleksander Kwaśniewski, and various childish masks borrowed from animated cartoons like a cow, a nerd, a gorilla, a donkey, and others. Throughout, a slide with the image of the Black Madonna of Częstochowa was projected onto my face, holding the power to be above all these layers. In the background, on a television, characters from a children's cartoon experienced their dramas, with their noises and conversations providing a surprising and ambiguous context, "commenting" on all my gestures. During the advertisement separating "Dobranocka" and "Wiadomości," I removed all the masks and applied a thick layer of powder to my face. The image of the Madonna became more visible on my face, while the background advertisement promoted a series of skincare cosmetics for women. During "Wiadomości," the first pieces of information conveyed were snippets from Aleksander Kwaśniewski's presidential oath. I cut my right cheek, guiding the razor blade in accordance with the scars on the face of the Black Madonna of Częstochowa.



Illustration 8: P. Wyrzykowski, still frames from video documentation, 1995, private collection.

This performance was a sequence of adopting various masks, changing faces, expressing the complete loss of the "I" in the diversity of created images, presented information, and manipulations of the media and politicians. It was the first such massive media campaign in the American style to which an unprepared society was subjected. At that time, both politicians accused each other of treason, espionage,

and lies. It was difficult to really take a side. The situation seemed like a comedic farce, a satire negating any values. It became impossible to answer the questions: is it true that I am this smiling face (meaning I don't use my face to force a smile shown to another person), am I in the world or in the body, and the pole of presence is another person to whom I smile, not my face, if it smiles at all? At this particular moment, my physicality had to redefine itself through self-harm, mark boundaries but also cross them, because the body has visible "boundaries", "stops", on the skin's surface, but its presence is constantly beyond that. I couldn't agree for my presence, through the manipulations of politicians, to be reduced to play and focus on itself. In such a situation, the world disappears and becomes a stage of performance with an endless empty mirror reflecting its own image. And since the world is a mirror that only reflects an image, presence literally "exhausts itself" in the body. I am no longer with myself and I am not here. My "I" vanishes.

Using performance art as a means of communication and responding to social changes, I found my place in a given, new situation. The above examples represent an important beginning of my artistic research on building connections and commenting on current events. Thanks to this strategy, whose central element is a close connection with social reality through performance art, I was able to move on to subsequent concepts based on transformism, directly related to the topic of my research.

CREATING REALITY – THE INVISIBLE WORK

The Invisible Work, also known as "invisible" or "absent," refers to a type of artwork that doesn't manifest in a physically present form or object but is based on ideas, concepts, or events that can be described or narrated verbally or in written form. Typically, the essence of the invisible work challenges traditional conceptions of art as a material object and questions the values attributed to the artistic object itself. Such works often focus on ideas, concepts, thought processes, as well as the emotions and reactions of the viewer, elicited by the concept of the work rather than its physical representation. An example of an invisible work is Yves Klein's piece titled "The Void." This work was first exhibited at the Galerie Iris Clert in Paris in

1968. Klein painted the room's walls white and left them empty. The words "Void" and "Heaven" were also placed on the walls.

Diminishing the materiality of the artwork and achieving an invisible form was one of the methods I employed in my attempts to penetrate the system. A non-substantial project, operating at the conceptual level or in a camouflaged, hidden form, effectively reduces the distance between the viewer and the work. As a result, it penetrates more easily and deeply, unnoticed, into the system, enabling the provocation of change. Often, participants in the project are unaware of their engagement with art, which diminishes their defensive reaction to encountering something unfamiliar or, in their understanding, too complex, facilitating significant contact. Bringing the language of art to a level of understanding, using comprehensible, identical codes and signs with the intended recipients, is one strategy that facilitates penetration and potential transformation.

**"120 hours of megatechno presence. Art is a cult space or there is no art,"
Temporary Workshop, Konin, 1994 (with Robert Mikołaj Jurkowski).**

The first project, which in an expanded performance form with site-specific installations, implemented the above strategy. Invited by Arek Woźniak, who runs the Pracownia Chwilową, to prepare an individual exhibition in Konin, I proposed to Mikołaj (Robert Jurkowski) a joint action. Why techno and why a club? At that time, the techno counter-culture had its emancipatory potential, engaging a large group of active participants and accumulating immense positive energy. Its affirmatory nature, often taking on an extremely hedonistic dimension, was crucial. For us, the strength of this phenomenon seemed ideal to tap into and use as a medium, *"designing new practices of perceiving reality and participating in it" for the mass audience.*²⁰

"In 1994, two artists from Gdańsk, Piotr Wyrzykowski and Mikołaj Jurkowski, transformed the Galeria Chwilową in Konin into a techno music club. For 10 days, the gallery, turned into a club, operated at night, organizing the best parties in the city, totaling 120 hours (hence the project name: 120h Mega Techno Presence). The subtitle of the exhibition was "Art is a cult space, or there is no art." Through

²⁰ Łucja Iwanczewska, "Potentiality of Transformation. Short Duration of Cultural Performances in Poland in the 90s". Warsaw: IBL. 2022.

entertainment, the artists aimed to attract individuals to the art gallery who might otherwise never have visited. They turned to techno, as it was a movement that allowed contact with a mass audience. It was essential to step outside the context of art and operate in direct contact with people. As Wyrzykowski said, the idea was to "use the party as a medium in which you can insert your information". Wyrzykowski played music, mixing it with quotes. Instead of classic sculptures, the artists presented objects supporting the party, such as a Greek column cut in half, made of plaster and filled with illuminated and heated honey with amphetamines, in which one could dip a finger and taste. The goal was to burst the balloon of pretentious contemporary art that repelled street people. To transform the "temple of art" into a place for everyone. Wyrzykowski recalls, "We didn't inform anyone about the gallery's change into a techno club, and that was also part of the strategy. It was characteristic of those times when suddenly a shop turned into a bank or vice versa. This is how the transformation of Poland manifested." However, the project quickly got out of control for the artists. Wyrzykowski recalls, "We had to flee from Konin because two rival micro-mafias wanted to take control of our club – they wanted us to start selling alcohol and drugs."²¹

²¹ Łukasz Ronduda and Zofia Krawiec, "Be Yourself, I'm With You: Rave Culture and Art in the 90s in Poland", Szum Magazine No. 14, 2016.



Illustration 9: Mikołaj Robert Jurkowski and Piotr Wyrzykowski, "120 H Mega Techno Presence", Temporary Gallery, Konin, 1994, photo by L. Krutulski, private collection.

This was one of the most intensively worked on 10 days, or rather nights. Everything took place in the basements of a socialist-modernist commercial complex in the middle of a grim housing estate with typical 4-story residential blocks around. An ideal place for our project, gloomy, with nowhere for the youth to go except stairwells and basements. Our basement, devoid of windows, painted black with a low ceiling and filled with specially designed authorial objects distributed in two rooms, looked like a dream come true in the eyes of the local teenagers: a techno club in Konin! Mikołaj prepared an installation consisting of a plaster Greek column, painted with orange ultraviolet paint, crowned with a capital in the form of an orange warbler. Next to it on the floor was a low fragment of a column with a glass vessel inside, filled with honey with amphetamines and illuminated by warm light, filling the room with a sweet smell. Dominating everything was typical disco dynamic lighting, projecting multicolored spots throughout the room. It was a favorite so-called chillout spot, where groups would linger for long lazy hours.

My room, which you entered directly from the street, descending long stairs down, was illuminated only by 2 UV lamps, which brought out from the dark violet glow,

brightly yellow sentences, quotes from my hypertext titled "On the developed body of technical culture". This was also a room filled with loud techno music, which I mixed live from two tape decks, weaving in previously recorded voice messages of the same sentences.

We operated from 6 pm to 6 am, with the youth flocking to us straight after school, enthusiastically sharing their techno recordings and urging me to play them. I sat behind the mixer, accepting new records and tapes, playing snippets, which I would quickly mute, returning to my tapes. Most of the suggested recordings were not the kind of techno music we wanted to fill the space with, without allowing for the slightest moment of silence. Mikołaj, in a white jumpsuit, glowing in ultraviolet light, magnifying his figure, roamed the gallery, greeting guests, encouraging them to go further. The funniest thing was that no one believed us that this was a contemporary art exhibition. At first, it didn't matter, but after a few days when word spread about our club, representatives of Konin's underworld started visiting us. They checked timidly at first, then more aggressively and boldly, trying to take control of the space, open a beer bar, and do some minor drug trade. Mikołaj's explanations that this was not a club, but rather an artistic form of action, seemed idiotic to them, and they couldn't understand why they should give up such a great opportunity. Mikołaj persistently guided the guests through the rooms and talked about our installations, undeterred by their reaction. A funny rumor arose that Arek had opened a club instead of a gallery and brought in a karateka in a white suit, Mikołaj, and a DJ with a lamp on his head, me, to get the business going. Sorry, but no... what mattered more to us was other youths, with whom we established contact and to whom, for the duration of our project, we showed that another world is possible, that their interests and passions make sense.

Escaping from Konin, leaving our cult place, we saved ourselves from young local gangsters trying to influence us too strongly, who dreamed of turning our action into their underground eldorado of illegal trade. The presence we set up in the project title and the creation of a place of worship came true the night after we left. The closed doors to the gallery with a letter to the participants glued on them burned down — a sacrifice was made.

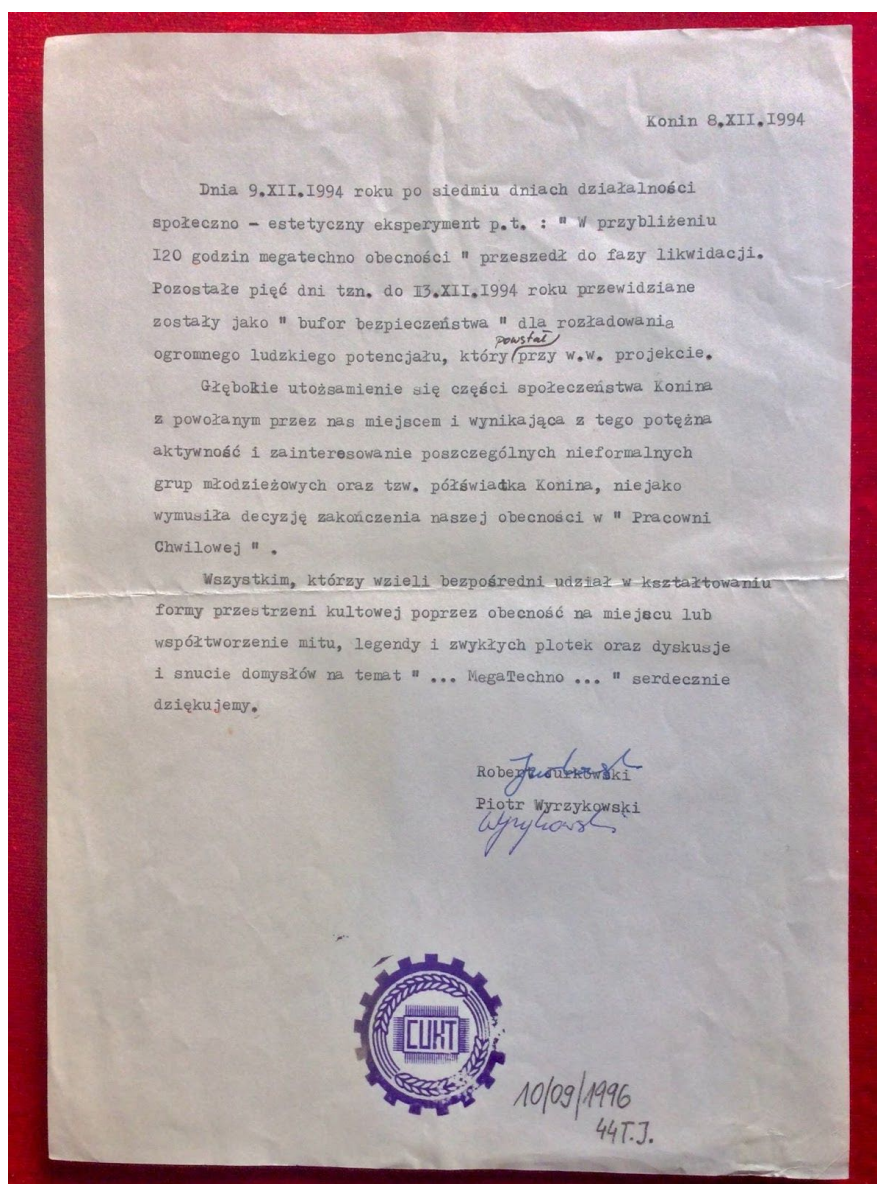


Illustration 10: Letter to participants, Temporary Gallery, Konin, 1994, private collection.

"The title, "120 H Mega Techno Obecności," with its subtitle "Art is a cult space or there is no art," defines its purpose in a manifesting style. The action was to create such a cult space by transforming a gallery into a techno club. Only the visible change of function traditionally assigned to the gallery caused its transformation into a place of art; it created conditions for the possibility of specifically contemporary art. The project lasted ten days. During this period, the gallery-club was open from 6 pm to 6 am, which is usual for a club but unusual for a gallery (in total 120 hours). The

*artists ran the club, meaning they took care of the interior decoration arranged by them with objects and installations, played music, but also cleaned, and maintained club order. The pro-social and educational direction of thinking about the actions undertaken and their address to the younger generation became apparent here. The gallery became a place of presence for people who otherwise would probably never appear in it. The strategy of transforming "art temples" into places "for everyone" and depriving art itself, at least the one usually cultivated in them, of its sacredness, which will be one of the iron rules of C.U.K.T., also succeeded here."*²²

On this occasion, I would like to mention our joint project with Mikołaj, which was not realized. We wanted to develop the above strategy: the invisible work of art. We proposed the project to Grzegorz Kłaman to be carried out in the Wyspa Gallery. The idea was significantly related to the context of the place, its function, but also provocatively addressed the history and character of the art associated with the Wyspa Gallery. At that time, Wyspa was located in the dormitory building of the Academy of Fine Arts on Chlebnicka Street, with a transitional small room behind a glass wall on the ground floor and the main hall upstairs. Our idea for the exhibition was to transform the gallery into a grocery store, which we wanted to run for a specified time, trading in the most needed products. Of course, according to our strategy, we intended to hide the authorial message among the assortment and use video transmissions from industrial cameras overseeing the shop shelves set up in the gallery to TVs hung on the ground floor, manipulating the video image transmitted in real time. The adopted strategy of drawing participants into the center of the designed artistic event guaranteed the successful participation of a large number of unaware viewers, as there was no grocery store nearby at the time, and students have their simple but significant needs.

The above projects were undertakings aimed not only at changing the perception of the gallery as a temple of art but also at including the local community in the creative process. Our goal was to open the gallery to a wider audience and, in the literal sense of the word, to consume culture in everyday life. We wanted to create a space where art and everyday life intertwined. Our strategy assumed that by transforming the gallery into a grocery store, using the element of surprise, we could reach a

²² Łukasz Guzek, „The Body Will”, 1999 <https://www.doc.art.pl/qg/wyrzyklipskfr.htm> (01.11.2023)

larger number of people and provide them with an artistic experience unavailable in everyday life, which they were afraid of and did not allow into their lives.

FAKE

Fake, meaning falsehood, forgery, or simulation, can be employed by artists as an artistic strategy to engage the viewer. Through the creation of an artificial reality into which the observer may immerse themselves, artists can influence the viewer, evoke emotions, and pose questions about the nature of reality and ways of perceiving it. An example of such a strategy is conceptual art, which often relies on creating fictitious situations or claims that require the viewer's engagement and reflection to understand their meaning. An illustration of this is the work "The Yes Men" by the artistic duo, Andy Bichlbaum and Mike Bonanno. As part of their practice, the artists craft fake websites and counterfeit personas to impersonate corporations, government institutions, and organizations whose actions they deem unethical. For instance, posing as representatives of Dow Chemical, the artists issued a fake statement about the Bhopal disaster in India that took place in 1984 and killed thousands. Their counterfeit statement caused significant media upheaval and helped refocus attention on corporate responsibility for environmental damage.

Victoria Cukt's Presidential Campaign", C.U.K.T., 1999 - 2000

As I mentioned earlier, the campaign with Victoria's presidency is undoubtedly one of the most vivid examples of transformism and works whose vitality in the form of informational resonance does not cease despite 23 years since its creation. Paradoxically, the entire campaign was a fake (like real politics), in contrast to the Danish Synthetic Party project from 2022, which seems to be a functioning artificial intelligence and clearly refers to our activity.

Victoria Cukt was a virtual, digital avatar, whose election program was based on the synthesis of postulates, carried out by the so-called OSW (Citizen Electoral System). Officially we claimed so, but I was handwriting the postulates submitted by people, no program was working, except for the website I wrote. Unlike the chatbot Lars from the Synthetic Party, which operates on the Discord platform. Both these initiatives,

although separated by over 20 years, are surprisingly similar. They represent attempts to repair democracy by allowing direct participation in decision-making through new media and artificial intelligence.

The Synthetic Party was founded in Denmark in May 2022 by the MindFuture Foundation and the Computer Lars art collective. The program of the Synthetic Party in Denmark is based on the operation of artificial intelligence called Lars, which communicates via a chatbot on the Discord platform and is responsible for synthesizing the voices of the excluded and processing them into a political program.

*"The revealed program elements include a promise to establish a basic income for everyone of 100,000 crowns per month (almost \$14,000, which is twice the average salary in Denmark) and to supplement the UN Sustainable Development Goals list with point 18 – 'Living with artificial objects'".*²³ Representatives of the Synthetic Party explain that they want to raise awareness of the importance of the role of artificial intelligence and synthetic technologies in everyday life and in decision-making in all dimensions of life. We, as C.U.K.T., in 2000 proposed the introduction of a law granting artificial intelligence legal personality and citizen status.

Victoria wanted to realize the vision of an information society led by AI. Victoria Cukt promoted the idea of "electronic democracy", which was to eliminate the representative system and liquidate the political class. In this vision, decisions were to be made directly by society via the internet, creating something she called the "Will of the Nation" and promoting the slogan "Politicians are redundant". Victoria Cukt's program aimed to accelerate the transformation of culture into technical culture. After 22 years, these ideas come to life and, if I may say so, materialize in the form of a bot launched by the Synthetic Party, which aspires to create an international movement to give power to artificial intelligence. I absolutely support this postulate.

23

[https://www.projektpulsar.pl/struktura/2185926,1,kulturalni-i-wulgarni--wirtualni-przywodcy-sonduja-mechanizmy-demokracji.read#:~:text=koron%20miesi%C4%99cznie%20\(prawie%2014%20tys. 01.10.23](https://www.projektpulsar.pl/struktura/2185926,1,kulturalni-i-wulgarni--wirtualni-przywodcy-sonduja-mechanizmy-demokracji.read#:~:text=koron%20miesi%C4%99cznie%20(prawie%2014%20tys. 01.10.23)



Illustration 11: C.U.K.T., billboard with Victoria Cukt, Gdańsk, 2000, private collection.

As you've highlighted, the campaign surrounding Victoria undoubtedly serves as a vivid example of how art, especially in its transformative and speculative forms, can intersect with and impact political and social realities. The campaign's ability to resonate over two decades after its inception speaks to the enduring power of art that engages critically with its sociopolitical context.

The comparison of Victoria Cukt to Magdalena Ogórek and the insinuation of their digital fabrication is a profound commentary on the ways in which political personas are crafted and presented to the public. This idea of politicians as 'creations' or 'avatars' rather than genuine representatives is an astute critique of modern political systems. Jędrzej Słodkowski's comparison of the two in the *Gazeta Wyborcza* article and Rafał Kalukin's piece in *Newsweek* underscore this sentiment, suggesting that the line between genuine political persona and digital construct can be increasingly blurred.

Moreover, the emergence of political movements or actions, like the establishment of computer stations in offices as you mentioned, that echo the campaign's tenets,

whether directly influenced or coincidental, shows the campaign's forward-thinking nature.

Recalling Łucja Iwnaczewska's thoughts, it's evident that art indeed serves as a potent vehicle for social and political change, particularly in Poland's transformative years during the 90s. By positioning art as an "archive of potentiality," it allows for the envisioning of alternative futures and realities. Artists, through their work, undertake a critical reflection on society and culture, transcending extant sociocultural boundaries. This intertwining of art and societal processes, as epitomized by the Victoria campaign, contributes to the broadening of societal imagination and showcases art's integrative role in societal processes.

ENTERING THE ROLE

An artist often has to play an assumed role to realize their project. In this way, they lower the vigilance of control systems and mislead the tools used to obtain consent for the project's execution. Additionally, artists can also disorient viewers by playing their role to exert more influence on them and evoke a surprise effect.

The artistic strategy of playing a role to achieve one's goal is one of the tools used by artists who want to implement projects that may be considered controversial or dangerous. By taking on a specific role, an artist can avoid excessive attention from control systems, such as city authorities or government agencies, which might try to block the project's realization.

Such a strategy might also involve the use of camouflage or hiding the artist's true intentions behind seemingly innocent or non-threatening projects. An artist can employ various techniques, such as image manipulation, camouflage, or obscuring the true nature of the project behind seemingly innocent premises, to achieve their goals.

An example of using this strategy is the already mentioned group, The Yes Men. This American duo often takes on the role of representatives of governments and institutions, then organizes fake press conferences, where they announce absurd, provocative projects, causing significant media resonance, drawing attention to selected social issues.

"Art Day", C.U.K.T., Gdynia Authorial High School, 1999.

Engaging with the state educational system involved transforming one day in a high school in Gdynia into a program led by C.U.K.T. officials. Additionally, we sent an official letter to the Polish president and parliament with a proposal to establish a new ceremonial day in the calendar of Polish national holidays: Art Day - 22.02. This day would be when artists open their studios and invite the public to meet, and special events promoting contemporary art are organized. Our initiative anticipated the Museum Night event.



Illustration 12: C.U.K.T., "Art Day", classes in technical music, led by Maciej Sienkiewicz, private collection.

The school's schedule for that particular day was modified in such a way that, for example, mathematics was replaced with computer science, and Polish language class was replaced with 'sink theory', etc. The students, arriving at school, were unaware of our intervention and were quite surprised to find that instead of a geography lesson, they had lectures on video art. Instead of their usual teacher, they

were greeted by a peculiar individual wearing a C.U.K.T. badge on their chest. Each of us prepared lessons or lectures on topics of our choice. We conducted lessons on: hypertext, 3D graphics, technical music, sink theory, sculpture, installation, and video art.



Plan lekcji „Dzień Sztuki” 22.02.1999

UCZNIOWIE	I A	I B	II A	II B	III A	III B	IV A	IV B
8.00-8.45	Teoria Zlewu		Rzeźba	Malarstwo	Video Art	Hypertext		Muzyka
SALA	I A		II A	I B	III B	komputerowa		IV A
8.50-9.35	Malarstwo	Rzeźba	Instalacja	Video Art	Hypertext	Grafika 3D	Muzyka	Teoria Zlewu
SALA	I B	II A	III A	III B	komputerowa	II B	IV A	I A
9.45-10.30	Rzeźba	Instalacja	Video Art	Hypertext	Grafika 3D	Muzyka	Teoria Zlewu	Malarstwo
SALA	II A	III A	III B	komputerowa	II B	IV A	I A	I B
10.40-11.25	Instalacja	Video Art	Hypertext	Grafika 3D	Muzyka	Teoria Zlewu	Malarstwo	Rzeźba
SALA	III A	III B	komputerowa	II B	IV A	I A	I B	II A
11.45-12.30	Video Art	Hypertext	Grafika 3D	Muzyka		Malarstwo	Rzeźba	Instalacja
SALA	III B	komputerowa	II B	IV A		I B	II A	III A
12.40-13.25	Hypertext	Grafika 3D	Muzyka	Teoria Zlewu		Rzeźba	Instalacja	Video Art
SALA	komputerowa	II B	IV A	I A		II A	III A	III B
13.30-14.15	Grafika 3D	Muzyka	Teoria Zlewu	Instalacja			Video Art	Hypertext
SALA	II B	IV A	I A	III A			III B	komputerowa
14.20-15.05		Teoria Zlewu		Rzeźba			Hypertext	Grafika 3D
SALA		I A		II A			komputerowa	II B

<http://cukt.art.pl>

Illustration 13: C.U.K.T., lesson plan, private collection.

Below: The official C.U.K.T. statement placed on the reverse side of the "calendar card".



CENTRAL OFFICE OF TECHNICAL CULTURE

ART DAY

Educational Performance

The Central Office of Technical Culture (C.U.K.T.) and the Association of Independent Schools announce the commencement of a series of educational and artistic activities aimed at permanently introducing the Art Day into the calendar of Polish national holidays and celebrations.

So far, the activities of the Central Office of Technical Culture have focused on generating artistic situations and attitudes in which the dominant factor was the artist's direct contact with the mass audience and initiating social discourses.

C.U.K.T.'s actions have never been limited to the elitist concept of the "realm of art," but in addition to creating "artistic realities," their aim was education and integration with society, especially with the youth.

The object of interest and the subject of C.U.K.T.'s activity are broadly understood socio-cultural changes, examining the state of knowledge about technical culture among young citizens, and encouraging them to use modern means of accessing information as freely as possible.

The "Art Day" project is directed to the students of the Gdynia Authorial High School and assumes replacing one day in the school's lesson plan with an authorial cycle of lectures and artistic educational activities. The primary objective of

the project is to acquaint young people with contemporary means of artistic expression and the current state of technical culture in the world and the country.

We hope that the first stage of our project implementation, in addition to us taking a voice in the general discussion on education reform, will become an opportunity to establish closer contacts, which will allow the continuation of the activities initiated by us and lead to the establishment of January 22 as Art Day in the official calendar of the Polish state.

C.U.K.T.

ARCHAEOLOGY OF THE FUTURE.

"Archaeology of the Future" is an artistic strategy that focuses on examining and interpreting possible future scenarios, trends, and phenomena. An artist employing this strategy aims to identify and depict futuristic trends, as well as to anticipate and represent the potential consequences of human actions.

Within this approach, artists often adopt an interdisciplinary stance, integrating science, technology, and art in their projects. Inspiration from past phenomena, as well as the application of archaeological methods to study the future, is also a significant aspect.

The objective of "Archaeology of the Future" is to highlight the fluidity and ambiguity of the future, emphasizing that its shape is contingent on numerous factors and the actions undertaken in the present.

An example of contemporary artworks aligning with the "Archaeology of the Future" method is the series by artist Walid Raad titled "The Atlas Group". This fictional group, created by the Lebanese artist, showcases the blending of two strategies: fabrication and archaeology of the future. Raad produced this series between 1999-2004, employing an interdisciplinary approach to probe and interpret possible scenarios linked to Lebanon's history.

"The Atlas Group" is a project wherein Raad pretends to be an archivist investigating covert archives about the Lebanese civil war. The artist crafts fictional documents, photographs, films, and narratives, implying the existence of classified reports, accounts, and events. While his pieces reference actual historical and political events, they incorporate fictional elements to explore possible future narratives and interpretations of these incidents.

Raad merges science, history, photography, and narrative in his projects to construct alternative histories and future scenarios. His methodology entails applying archaeological techniques to explore the past and analyze the future, allowing audiences to ponder how histories are constructed and how future events can be interpreted based on available evidence.

"How to Raise a Ruler? Discovered Fragments of the Manual", Imperial Castle, Poznań, interactive installation, 2011.

The project simulates an archival educational manual that could be discovered in the future and is displayed in the form of an interactive installation. It consists of 16 found pages and laws, with each page triggering an animation — a three-dimensional scene — a reconstruction representing specific political skills.

The hypothetical manual serves as a guide for the parents of rulers who need to raise their offspring with the destiny of taking over governance and leading a nation. The laws are sourced from Robert Greene's "48 Laws of Power."

The work is based on an augmented reality system. The viewer, holding the pages in various positions, can change the perspective of the 3D scene. A brief story is rendered on the surface of the page. Superimposed in real-time on the video camera feed, an added layer of 3D graphics and sound perfectly matches the "archival" card held by the viewer. The virtual graphics respond to changes in position and perspective, creating the illusion of "existence" on the real card viewed by the spectator. The viewer can see their hand, the page, and the animation on the video screen in front of them, observing from various perspectives and distances the short enactment illustrating the particular law.

We are dealing with a simulation of a simulation here. The non-existent ruler upbringing manual undergoes a process of recreation from potentially discovered

remnants. The game I introduce the viewer to is a two-level hallucination, aiming to subtly authenticate the message contained in the project.

TOOL — A FUNCTIONAL WORK OF ART.

The strategy of artistic projects that treat artworks as tools with a specific function, which not only possess aesthetic value but also serve a defined purpose. Through the viewer's use of the "tool-artwork," contact and transformation occur.

In 1988, Krzysztof Wodiczko designed and realized a project titled "Homeless Vehicle." It was a specialized vehicle intended for the homeless, designed to assist them in surviving the harsh conditions of urban spaces. The vehicle was crafted with the comfort and functionality of its users in mind. For instance, it featured specific compartments for clothing and sleeping bags, a foldable couch, storage for food and tools, as well as a lamp and heating device. It was also equipped with a particular lighting system intended to ensure the safety of its users in dark and dangerous locations.

Wodiczko's project was not merely a practical tool for the homeless, but it also aimed to sensitize society to the issue of homelessness and propose alternative solutions to this challenging situation. This work is a prime example of how an artwork can be utilized as a social tool, altering mindsets and attitudes towards significant social matters.

"Act for the City of Bytów", Bytów, C.U.K.T., 1996.

An invisible performance penetrating the core issue of unemployment and the actions undertaken by the state during this period.

The action involved an official contact between C.U.K.T. and the Bytów city office by sending a letter to the city's mayor and the head of the employment office, requesting the assignment of a workload of social works to C.U.K.T. officials, which could be carried out gratuitously for the benefit of the city of Bytów. An important context is that, during this period in Poland, an intervention work and public works program was launched for the unemployed. The city of Bytów had a very high unemployment rate at that time. A meeting took place at the city office, culminating in

the signing of an official agreement between the two offices. Under this agreement, we were assigned a week's worth of work: renovating tourist cabins in a recreation center and painting road stripes.



Illustration 14: C.U.K.T., C.U.K.T. officials against the backdrop of a renovated tourist house.

The project was so identical to reality that it became invisible and unnoticeable. Spectators coming to the site of our work claimed that nothing was happening there, nothing existed — just some guys renovating cabins. We carried out the work together with other workers from the city, spending together an 8-hour shift and meal breaks. A humorous conflict arose between us: the locals stated we were working too quickly, arguing that this pace was inappropriate because the work would run out. They taught us that we had to work more slowly and take breaks more often.

P O R O Z U M I E N I E

zawarte w dniu 28.06.1996r. pomiędzy Zarządem Miejskim w Bytowie
reprezentowanym przez:

Romana Zaborowskiego - Z-cę Burmistrza Miasta
Leszka Pałasza - Kierownika OKSiT

a Centralnym Urzędem Kultury Technicznej w Gdańsku reprezentowanym
przez:

Piotra Wyrzykowskiego - Członka CUKT
Jacka Niegodę - Członka CUKT
Robertą Jurkowskiego - Członka CUKT
Anny Nizio - Członka CUKT
Artura Kozdrowskiego - Członka CUKT
Rafała Grabowskiego - Członka CUKT

na wykonanie nieodpłatnie prac remontowo - malarskich na rzecz Miasta Bytowa
przez urzędników w/w CUKT w Gdańsku w dniach 26-28.06.1996r. w godzinach
8.00-16.00.

§ 1.

Członkowie CUKT w Gdańsku zajmą się pracami remontowo - malarskimi na rzecz
Miasta w zamian za to otrzymają nieodpłatnie wyżywienie i nocleg w dniach
26-28.06.1996r.

Brzek Patern
R. Zaborowski

Prof. Wyrzykowski
Nieofałd Jacek
Robert Wyrzykowski



Illustration 15: C.U.K.T., agreement between C.U.K.T. and the City Management in Bytów, 25.06.1996.

A page from the "Kurier Bytowski" with an article describing the C.U.K.T. performance. This article was created specifically for the sponsor of the action, ROBOD company, which provided the officials with work overalls and gloves for the job. This type of activity falls into the "Fake" strategy described above.



Illustration 16: C.U.K.T., forged page from the Bytów Courier, 1996.

MEDIA ATTACK – MASS VIEWER OF A TECHNO PARTY

Techno Party is a form of participatory art that uses new media and technology to engage a large group of participants, exceeding the usual number of gallery viewers. It is a cultural phenomenon that originates from electronic music and underground club culture. Techno Party is primarily a participatory experience that engages participants in the creative and artistic process through physical activity and direct participation in long-lasting mass performances. Due to its open, democratic, and appealing form, it attracts young people from various backgrounds and cultures who share a passion for music, art, and freedom.

Actions of this nature combine many forms of artistic expression into a single project, such as direction, set design, performance, video art, and lighting actions.

An example of similar actions can be the Tresor club in Berlin. Tresor is not only one of the most important techno clubs in the world but also a place where contemporary art exhibitions are organized. From the very beginning, the club was associated with Berlin's artistic and musical scene, and in later years it also became an important place for contemporary art.

In the 1990s, Tresor began organizing contemporary art exhibitions as part of its "Galeria Tresor" program. The goal was to create a space where artists could display their works and simultaneously strengthen the bond between the club scene and contemporary art. The initial exhibitions were organized in the club, and later in a separate space near the club.

In the 2000s, Galeria Tresor transformed into "Tresor Contemporary", which was dedicated exclusively to contemporary art. As part of this project, contemporary art exhibitions, performances, and installations were organized.

"Technopera", by C.U.K.T., CSW Zamek, Centrum WRO, in locations including Wrocław, Warsaw, Zielona Góra, and Gdańsk, spans from 1996 to 2023.

The project, executed across various locations and developed over time, takes the form of subsequent versions and stagings. The libretto of the "Technopera" is authored by Artur Kozdrowski and Piotr Wyrzykowski. It is conceived as an epic of technical culture. Other officials of C.U.K.T. involved in the realization of the

"Technopera" include Anna Nizio, Mikołaj Robert Jurkowski, Maciej Sienkiewicz, Ewa Adam Virus Popek, and Haleh Abhari.

This is a multimedia mass participatory performance. Personally, for me, it represents the ultimate conceptual level of performance art development (I won't delve into this thought here, as it's not the topic of this work, but multi-hour performances share many commonalities with the physical experiences of body art.). Like many other projects, it combines various strategies. Apart from the strategy being discussed in this section, "media attack - mass audience", the idea for realizing the "Technopera" arose from the strategy of "invisible work". That is, concealing the message, work in another form. Initially, people were invited to a rave with DJs, not expecting anything more than what they encountered elsewhere at other techno parties. In a way, that was the case, and it had to be, otherwise our strategy would have failed. During multi-hour parties (ranging from 12 to 32 hours), live music and parallel video projections were mixed with audiovisual samples from the libretto. Suddenly, an audio and graphic text, such as "Knowledge gives you power", would burst into a "standard" techno track.

The libretto consists of audiovisual samples from educational films and science fiction, arranged in the form of a dialogue between the opera's characters. The libretto, played live by a VJ, provides a choreographic and dramaturgical reference point for actors and musicians.

This form gradually evolved towards an elaborate standalone spectacle using video projections as scenography for the live performances of an opera soprano and a performer.



Illustration 17: C.U.K.T., "Technopera", WL4, Gdańsk, 2023, Photo: 3miasto_pl.

*"As an example of art popularization, one can refer to the 'Technoperas' - an innovative artistic format that redefined traditional reception strategies. The 'Technoperas' by the C.U.K.T. group, combining music, art, and new technologies, produced new communal practices post-1989 – utopian, anti-institutional, democratic. The artists associated the opera genre with high, elitist, exclusive art, inaccessible to the masses. Such that does not engage with the social space, does not seek to change it, and lacks agency. It serves solely to shape high, elitist tastes, reinforcing class and cultural inequalities. Thus, they turned to opera, envisioning democracy as a series of egalitarian, inclusive, and accessible cultural operations for those excluded from its impacts. The artists were concerned with institutions – galleries, universities, public offices. They sought to transform the organization of these institutions to finally serve the common good and massively transform society. Their actions primarily revolved around redefining existing models and ways of participating in public life."*²⁴

²⁴ Łucja Iwanczewska, "Potentiality of Transformation. Short Duration of Cultural Performances in Poland in the 90s". Warsaw: IBL. 2022.

PUBLIC SPACE PROJECTIONS

Video projections in public spaces are a significant example of interventionist art that uses the public environment as a medium for displaying dynamic moving images. This artistic strategy explores public places as potential screens for visual transmission, expanding the possibilities of creating artworks and their impact on the urban context.

The location where the video projection is placed, and its context, play a crucial role in shaping the artistic message. Each location where projections are displayed becomes an integral part of the work, influencing the reception of the video content. Simultaneously, creators use the video content itself as a tool to convey their artistic message.

A prime example of this creative strategy is the work titled "Hiroshima Projection" by Krzysztof Wodiczko, dated 1990. In this work, the artist used the facade of a building in Hiroshima as a projection surface, where images of hands were displayed. Though seemingly simple in form, this project held profound significance and symbolism. In human culture, hands represent communication, touch, and empathy. In the context of Hiroshima, this work became a symbolic reminder of the trauma caused by the atomic bomb explosion.

"I will give freedom to all of you," public space, Hamburg, 2002.

The creation of this artwork employed two strategies. The first was the strategy of public projection, and the second was the strategy of direct contact, co-creation, and the act of transferring through a medium to another dimension, with the aim of transforming the consciousness of the boys participating in the project. I employ a very similar strategy in the artistic part of my doctoral work, which I will discuss in more detail below.

In the discussed project, I invited two homeless boys, whom I had met on the streets of Kyiv, to collaborate. As always in such cases, gaining trust is paramount. It's best to seek the assistance of someone who has already gained this trust and has known

the individuals for a longer period. This is precisely the approach I took, asking a friend who worked with the homeless on a long-term project for help.

I proposed to Kolya and Serozha (the names of my protagonists) that I would like to make a film with them. Specifically, I wanted to capture shots simulating them flying, soaring like birds in the sky. My goal was to record their performances and then "illegally" transport them to Hamburg (to the West) for display in the city's public space. After completing the documentation and returning to Kyiv, I showed Kolya and Serozha how they "flew" in Germany.



Illustration 18: P. Wyrzykowski, video projection in a residential window, still frames from video, Hamburg, 2002.

INSTITUTION AS ART

The artistic strategy "Institution as Art" involves creating fictional institutions that resemble existing state or private institutions of power. These fictitious institutions aim to provoke reflection on the nature of power and institutions, their functions and mechanisms of action, as well as how they influence people's lives.

Within this strategy, artists often produce fictional documents, such as application forms, declarations, regulations, and certificates, to give their institutions a more authentic character. Often, these documents contain provisions that contradict commonly accepted norms or address existing social issues.

At this point, a description of the NSK (Neue Slowenische Kunst) project is essential. NSK is an artistic group active since the 1980s, which created a fictitious state called "NSK State in Time." This project aimed to confront existing political structures and create an alternative state model based on the idea of art and culture, rather than national identity. NSK created state symbols, citizenship certificates, and issued its travel documents. This project was a form of institutional critique that challenged prevailing orders and power while simultaneously showing that art can influence social reality.

C.U.K.T. Central Office of Technical Culture", 1995 to 2000.

In the activities of C.U.K.T. (Central Office of Technical Culture), I see a direction that could be described as "transformist". Our collective was not just a gathering group of artists; we were an institution, without being an institution in the traditional sense; we were a work of art that questioned and deconstructed the very principles of institutionalism. We were an anti-institution, possessing all bureaucratic attributes—logos, seals, corporate letters, cyclical meetings, and resolutions taken—but without any real executive power. Except for great enthusiasm and a sense of the need to act. This false institutionalism was a tool, not an end. It allowed us to engage with reality from a completely different perspective: not as individual artists, but as a "central office".

This shift was not accidental. When we decided to create this "false institution", we also relinquished individuality in favor of collective consciousness, aiming to change the mode of dialogue and actions. In this new form, the conversation was no longer with an individual artist but with a "central office". This provided us with a platform to conduct broad interventionist actions, both in the realm of art and society.

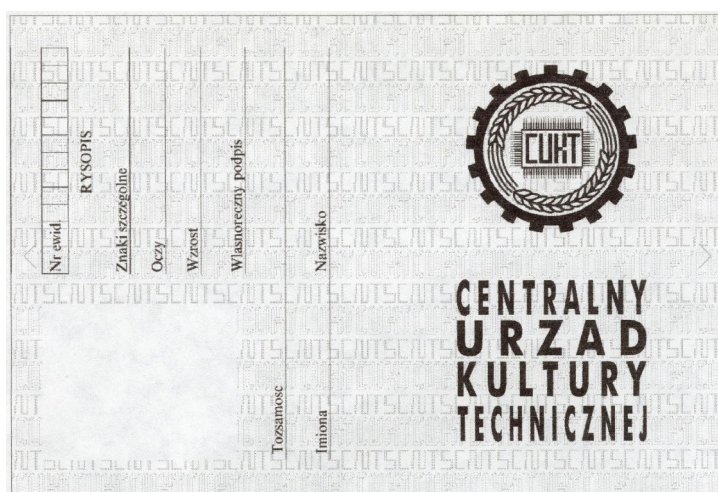


Illustration 19: C.U.K.T., Virus, badge design project, 1995.

Our activity was a symptom of modernity and a laboratory intertwining of various orders of contemporary reality. In this context, I see our work as a form of "artistic activism", which, using various forms and mediums, aimed to evoke real changes in the socio-political reality. Techno and new technologies, which were key elements of our practice, were not just tools of expression for us, but also forms of commentary on the impact of technology on society and culture.

As a result, C.U.K.T.'s activity can be analyzed as a practical realization of theoretical assumptions about the potential of art as a tool for conscious transformation. We were not only commentators on reality but also its active participants, using aesthetic and conceptual tools to evoke real changes.

Creating a fake, yet fully functional "institution" was a means for us to investigate how institutional forms and structures influence the production and perception of art and socio-political discourses. This institutionalism was both a medium and a material of our artistic practice. It allowed us to challenge established hierarchies and power mechanisms, thereby introducing new models of interaction and dialogue.

The aim of this strategy was not only understanding but also change. Instead of being merely a critical commentary on institutions, we became an active intervention that both analyzed and influenced reality. We were an institution, but an institution that became a tool for questioning and transforming both the artistic and social spheres.

In this sense, our work was consistent with the idea of transformism—we desired for art to become a tool for conscious transformation. Through our fake institutionalism, we aimed to evoke real changes, both in the field of art and in a broader social context. We were, one could say, an institution in a state of constant self-transformation, always open to new possibilities and challenges.

DIGITAL UTOPIAS

Digital utopias, as an artistic strategy, are based on the possibilities brought about by the network society described by Manuel Castells. In a world where informational networks become a key tool for communication, interaction, and dynamically constituted identity, there arises a natural desire to explore how these tools can be used to create visions of ideal worlds. In an environment where the boundaries between reality and virtuality become increasingly blurred, artistic projects that seek to expand human identity and consciousness through digital media are intriguing experiments.

The Australian artist, Stelarc, with his experiments at the intersection of body and machine, provides a fascinating perspective on how technology can extend and alter human experience. His project "Third Hand" is a classic example of this idea. He attempts to integrate technological augmentation with the human body, creating a hybrid that challenges traditional notions of humanity. Can the "third hand", operating independently but in harmony with the two biological ones, become part of our identity? What other forms of "self" can emerge in a world where technology and biology are closely intertwined?

"Temporary Nation", 2021-22 (with Echo Ho)

Being one of my most technologically advanced projects, it developed the idea of performance art into a form of a networked global participatory performance. The "Temporary Nation" project was a global network performance aimed at creating a temporary community. It explored the potential of a group of individuals in provoking real socio-political changes. It was based on a mobile application that transformed

the smartphone into an instrument for group co-creation of an audiovisual performance. Through physical gestures with their phone, users activated sounds and animations. The performance was global, enabling collaboration both locally and over the Internet. An important aspect of the project was to emphasize the power of the community and counteract the atomization of society, often a result of individual use of technology. The project had a utopian dimension, highlighting the idea of community and collective creation. Every user was both a creator of generated sounds and choreography and a recipient of the whole, all participants of the global event. The central element of the project was to engage users in active creation and interaction. By using specific hand gestures, wrist movements, or even the entire body, users could activate sounds and animations in the app, co-creating the sound choreography in this way. Instead of the traditional passive consumption of content, users became active participants, engaging in dynamic and interactive artistic experiences. Thanks to the ability to connect with other users both locally and globally through the network, the project promoted the idea of a global creative community that transcends traditional geographical and cultural boundaries.

The aforementioned selected projects and artistic strategies showcase a diversity of methods employed by myself and other artists to engage in a dialogue with reality, using art as a tool for social transformation. These artistic endeavors aimed not just to provoke reflections on the existing contexts, institutions, and power dynamics of their time, but also to create alternative social and political models based on the principles of co-creation and participation.

These artistic projects were crucial steps in examining the influence of art on social and cultural realities and in the evolution of my unique communicative language. Their objective wasn't just to stimulate reflection but also to conceive alternative models and potential developmental avenues for society.

Within my artistic portfolio lies a vast array of strategies I've undertaken in subsequent projects, always seeking the most direct form of contact with the audience. This diversity isn't just an aesthetic choice, but also a methodological pursuit of the most effective means to impact the viewer and a response to the ever-changing world and modes of communication. In this context, my works aren't merely art pieces but tools for conscious transformation.

For instance, my interactive installations aren't just aesthetic structures; they're dialogic spaces where the viewer becomes an active participant. By engaging with the artwork, the viewer transitions from a passive entity to an active participant, which aligns with my investigations into transformism.

Similarly, the utilization of performance in my artistic practice isn't arbitrary. This art form uniquely captivates audiences on both emotional and intellectual levels. Emotions here act as catalysts for engagement, be it positive or negative, potentially leading to change. A remarkable value and unique attribute of performance art lie in its immediacy, expressive speed, and the artist's ability to produce works without significant resources.

In essence, the variety of relational strategies I employ constitutes a methodological approach to exploring the potentials of art as a tool for conscious transformation. Each of these forms and strategies is an experiment within the broader context of a "transformation laboratory." *"A laboratory is a space in anticipation of the unknown, which, through experiments and countless trials, gains significance for social knowledge and practices."*²⁵

²⁵ Łucja Iwanczewska, "Potentiality of Transformation. Short Duration of Cultural Performances in Poland in the 90s". Warsaw: IBL. 2022.

CONCEPT OF THE PROJECT "TRANSFORMISM - KHODA"



Illustration 20: P. Wyrzykowski, Victoria and Anna, projection on a building, Królikarnia Street, Gdańsk, 2023.

"Transformism — KHODA"

As part of the artistic component of my PhD thesis, I am engaged in a comprehensive creative process comprised of diverse activities aimed at creating a multi-channel video installation. The goal of this project is to initiate a transformation process among its participants: three women with children who have found temporary refuge in Gdańsk.

Beyond the individual, group action is an essential feature of transformism. Such a strategy will be employed in the planned project titled: **"Transformism — KHODA"** (KHODA stands for Kharkiv Regional State Administration). Its objective is to provoke a change in the way the film's heroines perceive themselves. During the project, they undergo a transformation from refugees to film heroines and to superhero figures. Individuals with extraordinary powers that enable them to penetrate through building walls, traverse space in an instant, and achieve superhuman sizes, thereby becoming doubly present and visible in our shared space. How do I achieve this? Through video projections on building facades, which transfer the recorded heroines from their enclosed interiors of temporary homes to the outside. In this way, the huge, scaled, moving images with their portraits and voices become part of the public space, provoking reactions from passers-by.

The main goal of the project is to provoke a change in the way we perceive the relationship between society (group), state (organization), and individual, as well as to analyze the role that art can play in this process.



Illustration 21: P. Wyrzykowski, Victoria and Anna, projection on a school building, Śluza Street, Gdańsk, 2023.

Idea

The project envisions the creation of a film that will showcase sequences depicting the camera's transition from public space into a private interior, then to damaged rooms, and finally returning to public space. The film will consist of shots taken inside the temporary homes of refugees fleeing the war in Ukraine, as well as video projections onto building facades. The recorded interior shots will be used to prepare the outdoor projections. The visual material I will use to direct the projections is video footage of the damaged interiors of the Kharkiv Regional State Administration building, which was bombed by Russian rockets on March 1, 2022. The edited film is intended to have the effect of a continuous shot, with the camera constantly moving forward into the frame through the destroyed interiors, the city, and the residences, united with the new inhabitants by a shared dream of peace and a return home.

The projections will be one-time events lasting one evening, and their main objective is to capture video footage during the event. The ultimate result of the project is a film, and in the subsequent phase, a display in a gallery space in the form of a spatial multi-channel video installation.

The main subjects of the project are three families: Victoria with her daughter Anna, Tatiana and her son Andriy, and Valentina with her daughter Bohdana. They came to Gdańsk seeking refuge from the war in Ukraine.



Illustration 22: P. Wyrzykowski, Victoria and Anna, temporary shelter, Gdańsk, 2023.

In the context of the "Transformism — KHODA" project, trust and privacy cannot be overlooked, as without them the entire process would be impossible to conduct. Together with my wife Tamara, we built a profound relationship based on simple human solidarity and the desire to help them in their predicament.

Opening our doors and hearts to these families was a natural response to their needs upon arriving in Gdańsk due to the conflict in Ukraine. The attempt to step into their world and provide support during challenging times was the result of a basic human impulse. The trust and community that emerged from these actions later became the foundation for the depth and authenticity of the entire project. These private interactions, conversations, shared moments, or even mundane outings for

shopping and addressing everyday challenges became a kind of prelude to the more formal stage of shooting in their temporary homes. All of this was crucial for the depth and authenticity of the project, vital in the context of my research on transformism.

In summary, our long-term collaboration and close relationship with the project's protagonists were not only the foundation for the artistic project but also evidence of how privacy, daily life, and professional spheres can intersect and mutually enrich each other, thus creating conditions for a deeper, more authentic form of art.



Illustration 23: S. Stecenko, destroyed interior of the Kharkiv Regional State Administration, still frame, 2022.

Development

Artists, like every individual, have the right, and sometimes the duty, to comment on the events surrounding them. These comments sometimes become cultural icons. In 1814, Francisco Goya, through his painting "The Third of May 1808," commented on the tragic death of the Madrid insurgents. In 1819, Theodore Gericault's canvas "The Raft of the Medusa" shook the world's conscience by depicting the disgraceful abandonment of some shipwreck survivors by Captain Hugues Duroy de Chaumareys of the frigate La Meduse. Following World War I, George Grosz, Otto

Dix, and Max Beckmann dramatically commented on the war's tragedy that devastated Europe and its society through their paintings, drawings, and graphics. In 1937, Pablo Picasso, who typically avoided political subjects, presented a painting at the World Exposition in Paris depicting the massacre of the inhabitants of the Spanish town of Guernica, bombed by Francoist forces supported by German and Italian fascists. To this day, it remains one of the most iconic anti-war symbols. Andrzej Wróblewski's series of eight paintings titled "Executions," painted in 1949, is one of the most poignant chronicles of the civilian population being murdered during World War II. The monumental tragedy of the bombings during this war was captured by Ossip Zadkine. I'd like to quote a comment by one of the most outstanding and seemingly underrated Polish artists, Władysław Hasior, regarding the monument "Torn City": *"Great artists sometimes managed – I don't know if instinctively or in a programmed way – to replace the artistic symbols long in use with new ones, becoming from then on an extremely important and potent symbol, even a cultural journalistic argument. Such a new symbol, I believe, became Zadkine's 'Man with a Torn Heart,' a monument that was supposed to stand in Warsaw but ultimately stands in Rotterdam. As a sculptor, I am of course a bit envious that someone managed to create such a new sign of great artistic value, not remaining in the cultural tradition's grooves."*²⁶

It's worth mentioning the American artist Leon Golub and his paintings from the "Vietnam" series, as well as the "Interrogations" series. "Vietnam II" from 1973, owned by London's TATE and measuring 3 meters in height and 12 meters in length, depicts the horrors of the Vietnam War. American artist Martha Rosler, in her anti-war collages, touched upon the media portrayal of wars and our increasing indifference to dramatic reports. The first series, "Bringing the War Home: House Beautiful" from 1967-74, showcased collages with wounded, burned, or dead soldiers, children burned with napalm, integrated into the beautifully cataloged interiors of American homes, referring to the Vietnam War. Under the same title in 2004, a series emerged showing military actions from the Iraq War, incorporated into another series of beautiful catalog interiors. Colombian artist Fernando Botero, known for his genre scenes paintings of "plump" women and men, and idyllically

²⁶ Wiesław Darkiewicz, Between Tradition and Innovation – an interview with Władysław Hasior, "Cultural Weekly", 1977, No. 30. Zadkine, Torn City, Rotterdam, 1953.

monumental sculptures of people and horses XXL, shocked by reports of the tortures Americans committed in an Iraqi prison, painted the "Abu Ghraib" series in 2005 depicting the horror of dehumanizing an individual during another war. One of the outstanding global artists addressing the topic of war for years is Krzysztof Wodiczko, a visual artist and theorist born in Warsaw in 1943, currently a professor at Harvard's Media Art Department. The most touching to me are his "Hiroshima Projections" from 1999. The projection on the architectural ruins of the Exhibition Center in Hiroshima, the only remaining building near the epicenter of the explosion - Genbaku Dome, essentially on the promenade under the building. Wodiczko displayed projections showing the rescaled, moving hands of the victims and their families during interviews, and their accounts were broadcast from speakers, giving the impression that the building's remnants, projections, and their reflection in the river became the narrators of these tragic stories. Another outstanding work by this artist is the "Veterans' Torch" presented in Wrocław in 2010. In this work, the artist recorded a candle flame moving to the breath exhaled by Polish veterans of the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, or their family members. The projection of the flame moving to the spoken words on the "Partisan Hill" is a touching anti-war testament.

The artistic part of my doctorate fits into the anti-war, anti-violence long-standing tradition of artworks voicing concerns influenced by current significant events.

I cannot remain indifferent in the face of the dramatic events beyond our eastern border for two main reasons: personal (my wife is from Kyiv; we lived there for a long time, have family, and a vast circle of friends there) and the belief that the war in Ukraine is the "mother event," using the concept of Jean Baudrillard. The researcher, who claimed that we live in a world of simulations and hyperreality devoid of real reference, then wrote (11.09.2001): *"The attack on New York and the World Trade Center [...] is an absolute event, a 'mother' event, a pure event that contains all the events that never took place."*²⁷

Russia's brutal crimes committed on innocent people demand a response. I hadn't thought about creating artwork directly addressing this topic until I received video footage of the destroyed building of the Kharkiv regional administration. The images of the ruined interiors struck me with tremendous force. The silence captured in them

²⁷ Ewa Domańska, "Affirmative Humanities — Gender and Power after Butler and Foucault", In Contemporary Culture. Theory, Interpretation, Practice. Warsaw: NCK, 2014.

after a powerful explosion on the monumental Freedom Square, as a result of which a massive shockwave destroyed all the building's floors, continues to resonate in my head, leaving me restless. The juxtaposition of untouched, opulent Soviet decorations with the chaos of destruction creates a message rich in meaning and contrasts. But there's also something challenging to come to terms with – it's a beautiful image, fascinating (and I know I'm contradicting myself). It's an image of transformation. A change touching deep history – paradoxically, Russian missiles de-Sovietized the interiors of the Ukrainian administration building, tearing decorative five-pointed stars from the walls.

The building of the regional authorities in the Stalinist imperial style was built in its current version in 1954. It is already the 5th version of a structure located in this place.

- The first building in the Neo-Renaissance style was built between 1897-1899, and it housed the landowners of the province, equivalent to the district council.



Illustration 24: I building

- In 1914, the house was expanded with a two-story wing on the south side. On the drawing below, on the left side.

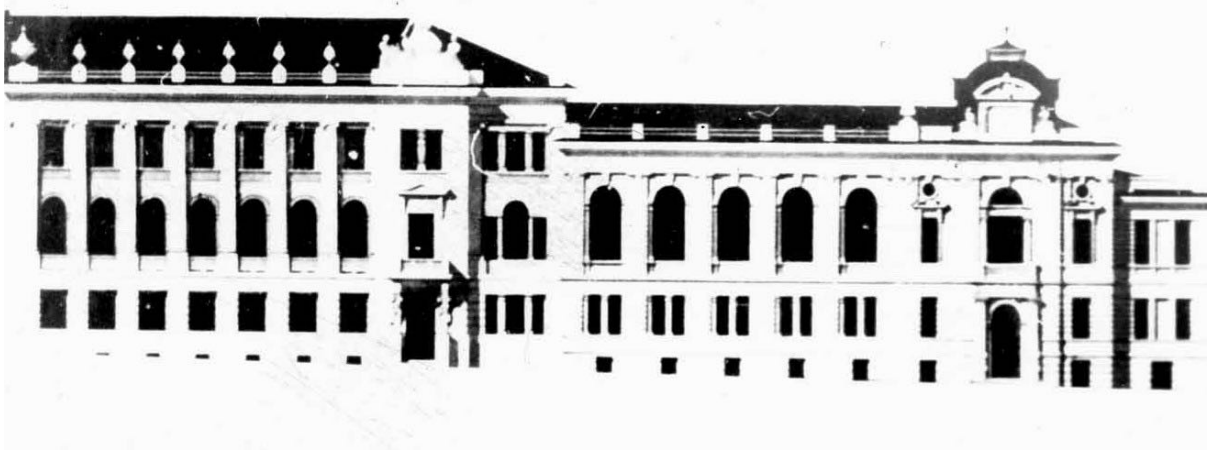


Illustration 25: II building

- In 1931, the building was renovated to serve as the headquarters for the communist party in the constructivist style. Interestingly, the architect (Yakov Steinberg) decided to retain part of the facade of the mansion.



Illustration 26: III building

- In 1932, the decorative elements of the historical facade fell off, and a decision was made to maintain the entire building in the constructivist style.



Illustration 27: IV building

- The constructivist architecture was destroyed due to wartime actions in 1943.
- In 1954, based on the design by architects Beniamin Kostenko and Vladimir Orehov, a new district administration building was constructed. The surviving elements of the foundations from previous structures were used to erect the current building.
- On March 1, 2022, two Russian Kalibr missiles, with a 7-minute interval between explosions, partially destroyed the building. As a result of the explosion, 24 people died.



Illustration 28: M. Rozenfeld, still frame from a film, 2022.

In 2014, the Kharkiv administration was illegally taken over twice by so-called separatists, who hoisted the Russian flag on the building's roof. These provocations were quickly addressed within a day, and the Ukrainian flag was restored to its place. Documentary video footage by Sergei Stecenko undergoes specific modification. He makes a subtle intervention using artificial intelligence to stretch the video in time, achieving a super slow-motion effect where the camera movement becomes barely noticeable. This allows for a meditative and extremely detailed tracking of the changing parts of the deserted interiors. The process to which he subjects the films involves generating non-existent video frames. Based on existing visual information, AI adds new, perfectly realistic frames between those already recorded. The moving image achieves a "freezing of time" effect. This allows us to see what might otherwise escape our attention. This technique equips our perception with a pseudo-scientific tool to trace the marks of abrupt change.

The war in Ukraine forced a significant change in my initial artistic project. Once again, reality, and my identification with it, provoked my response and decision.

The images of destruction captured on video represent a kind of transformation I hadn't envisioned when tackling this topic in my doctoral work. These images are a brutal reflection of the transformation that Vladimir Putin and his supporters wish to impose: transformation through destruction, terror, and violence. In an instant, a complex world full of people, functions, and meanings is reduced to dust and rubble. It's transformation in its most destructive form, generating chaos. Simultaneously, it

is an attempt to halt socio-political transformation not only in Ukraine but also in global consciousness. Putin not only wants to halt time but also reverse its course, manipulating identity, affiliation, and a misconstrued sense of patriotism. His criminal aggression towards Ukraine is an attempt to rewind history to before the fall of the Berlin Wall, serving an imperial vision of Russia.



Illustration 29: S. Stecenko, destroyed interior of the Kharkiv Regional State Administration, still frame, photos, 2022.

Here are the words of Yuriy Andrukhovych: *"Ukraine is a unique country for Russia. When the Muscovite kingdom was being transformed into a new empire in the 18th century, led by Peter I and then Catherine II, there was a demand for a foundational myth. This myth was crafted, suggesting that Russia's history reaches back to ancient Kyiv. This was an act of identity theft, even a name theft, as our name 'Rus' was transferred to them as 'Rossiya'. This theft persisted into the early 1990s, first under the guise of the Russian Empire and then the USSR."*²⁸ This statement carries extra weight. The Russian manipulation of Ukrainian identity resembles a collective facial transplant imposed by force. It is a violation of identity, of the very essence of being.

²⁸ Jurij Andruchowycz, ZNAK, No. 5/2022.

In my research and artistic practice, transformism is linked to the continuous dynamics of identity, body, and power. Who we are, and who we believe ourselves to be, is in constant transformation. And this should be our voluntary choice. Putin and his followers, by kidnapping Ukrainian children (about 14,000 according to recent reports), attempt to enslave this dynamic, imposing a single, monolithic concept of "self." This is a malevolent transformation, a transformation through dictatorship and crime, serving a privileged, narrow group holding power.

In this context, my work "Transformism — KHODA" becomes not just an artistic investigation but also a moral imperative. It is my attempt to oppose evil through creation, engagement, and truth. This is my effort to employ art as a tool for conscious transformation in the face of a world increasingly tainted by these crimes and evils.

"TRANSFORMISM — KHODA", VIDEO INSTALLATION VISUALIZATIONS

Illustration 30: Object in the center of the gallery with double-sided video projection, dimensions approximately 700 × 400 cm.



Below is a link to a preliminary, provisional version of the film material, an unfinished working version.

<https://youtu.be/gRiNFwFYfgE>

Illustration 31: "Transformism - KHODA", exhibition visualization.

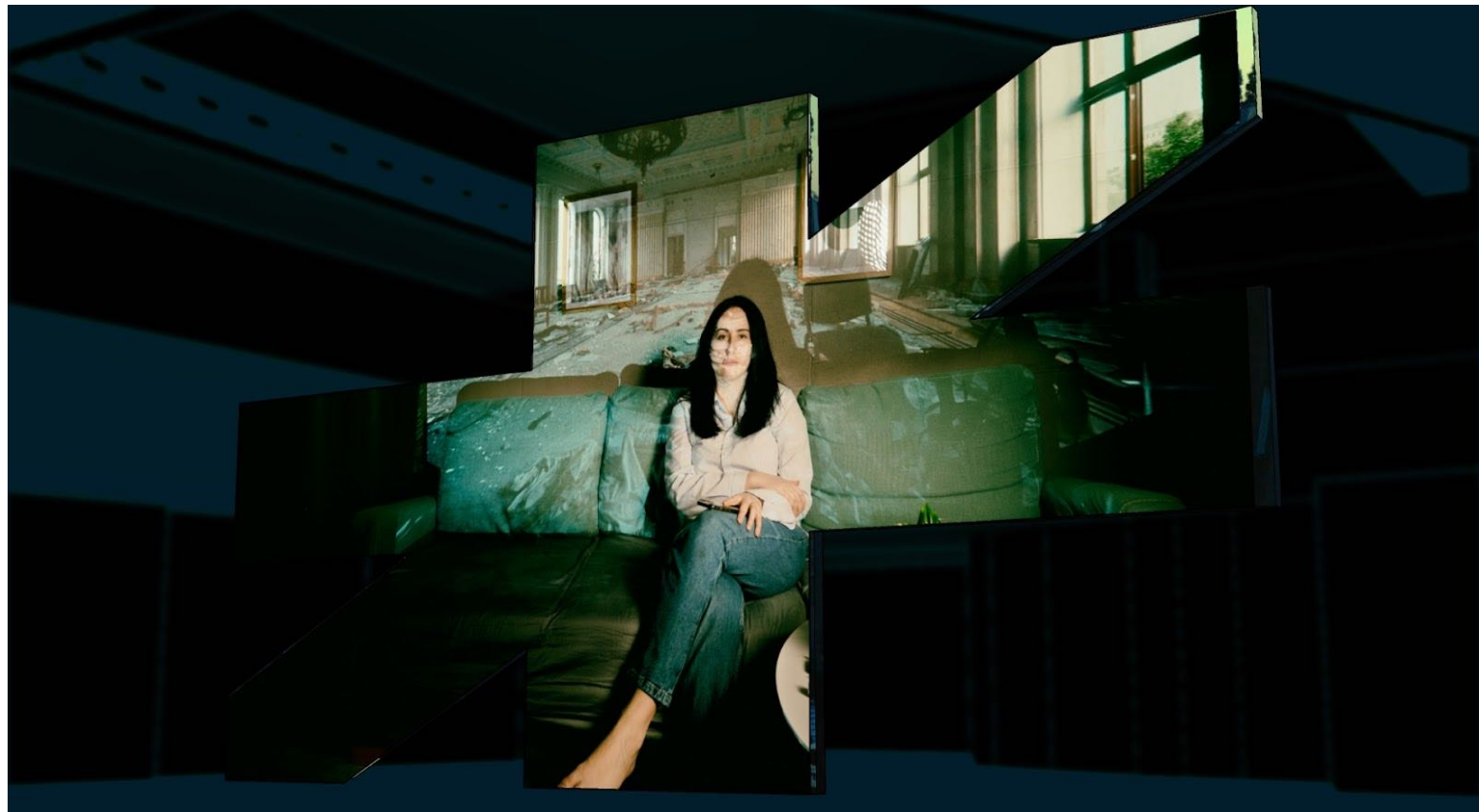


Illustration 32: "Transformism - KHODA", exhibition visualization.

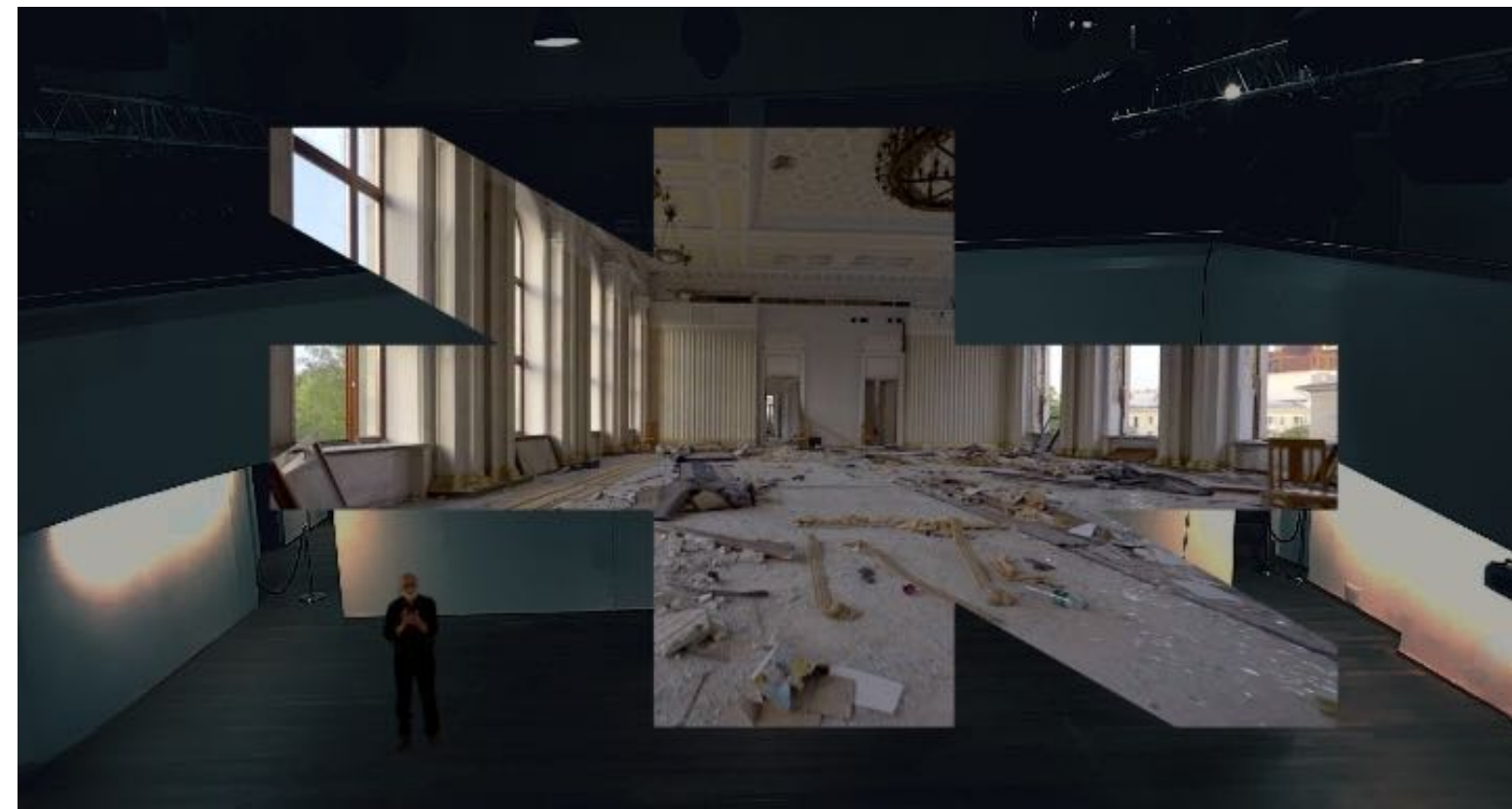


Illustration 33: "Transformism - KHODA", exhibition visualization.



Illustration 34: "Transformism - KHODA", exhibition visualization.



CONCLUSION

The presented vision of transformism is an ideal, perhaps a utopia. It's not the reality of art but represents an important horizon worth aiming for. It's something with potential for the future, or "l'avenir," as Derrida stated.

While working on the doctoral thesis and examining the posited hypothesis, in conclusion, I'd like to mention another strategy that could be employed within transformism: the concept of art as a journey through time. I'm not suggesting that one can create a piece that would transport us into the future like a time machine. Instead, I refer to the ability of a work to conceptually and informatively summon phenomena, solutions, or situations that might only emerge in the future and currently seem implausible due to technological, political, or social constraints. In this light, art can be perceived as a medium that not only unveils new horizons but also alters our perception of reality. Drawing a parallel to science, just as theoretical physicists posit the existence of yet undiscovered particles or dimensions, an artist, through their work, can suggest the existence of a world yet to come, but whose outlines we might begin to discern through their craft. Transformism, with its capability to envision and shape futures, might be a catalyst guiding us towards another (not necessarily better) tomorrow.

In today's times, transformism might hold another distinct significance. With technological advancements and the democratization of access to information, as well as the widespread manipulation of content, art can serve as a tool to combat cultural and political hegemony and social injustice. Artistic projects, especially those executed in public spaces, can serve as a means to express opposition against imposed norms, conventions, and the prevailing culture. In this manner, art can contribute to the democratization of culture and public space.

The belief in the necessity of introducing changes can be a curse, applicable equally to art and life. It's an attitude that, on one hand, motivates action and the ceaseless pursuit of new solutions and ideas, but on the other, can induce anxiety and uncertainty. It positions the artist as a "being-in-process," always seeking, never complete, looking for new modes of expression, and experimenting with various forms and communication techniques.

At the same time, this conviction doesn't imply that every change leads to improvement. However, stagnation and a lack of evolution aren't the answers either, as the world around us constantly evolves. Hence, changes are essential and inevitable.

Transformation remains the only constant in both life and art. A world that stagnates ceases to exist. Therefore, art must be current and reflect the reality in which we live. An artist embarking on this creative and life path must possess a particular resilience, *"to endure and undergo a continuous stream of transformation."*²⁹

²⁹ Rosi Braidotti, "Ethics of Becoming Undetectable", Trans. Joanna Bednarek. In *Subversive Theories: Anthology of Translations*, ed. Agnieszka Gajewska. Poznań: Wydawnictwo Poznańskie, 2012.

Transformism, as the main theme of this dissertation, is not merely a theoretical construct or artistic whim. It's a tangible mechanism through which art influences social, political, and cultural contexts. Over the years of my artistic practice, from performance to video works and installations in public spaces, I've observed a constant: the potential for change. Art is not merely a passive reflection of reality; it actively participates in its creation. In this sense, transformism is not just a concept, but also an ethic. It addresses questions about the artist's role in society and how art can serve as a tool for social influence.

In the digital age, where access to information equates to access to power, art is not only a medium of communication but also a form of resistance. Artistic projects in public spaces, from graffiti to multimedia installations, can function as social commentaries, expressing opposition against cultural and political hegemony.

In summary, transformism is not just an artistic concept but also a social and political one. It has the potential to shape our reality on various levels, from individual consciousness to social and political structures.

In a lecture delivered by Prof. Krzysztof Wodiczko upon being awarded an honorary doctorate at the Gdańsk Academy of Fine Arts in October 2023, the strategy of group work, dialogue, and the creation of opportunities for loud public testimony, which I applied in my artistic project "Transformism — KHODA," surprisingly confirmed its potential effectiveness and rationality for me. Allow me to quote selected excerpts as a summary:

*"Visibility and public testimony are closely linked to emerging from traumatic, heavy experiences. In the opinion of trauma theorist and clinician Judith Harmon, as well as Wanda Colcka, attempts to emerge from the psychological pit of trauma, finding a narrative voice through testimony, are more likely to succeed if performed in the form of a public act of speech. Even greater chances are there for those individuals when their statements, testimonies are directed as a social statement to others and on behalf of those others. In this way, telling the truth and bearing witness gain healing power, healing for both them and democracy. People can introduce these experiences into public discourse. Concurrently, we must help create conditions for what they say to be heard by others, whose perspective can change thanks to these new democratic entities."*³⁰

In the context of the words quoted by Prof. Krzysztof Wodiczko, I believe that art has a real ability and potential to provoke changes in consciousness, and my artistic activity since 1993 and the project "Transformism - KHODA" fully realizes this postulate.

³⁰ Krzysztof Wodiczko, lecture, Gdańsk, ASP, 2023.

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